

The Foreign Policy Impact of Trade-Based Status Gains: When China Overtakes the US as Top Export Destination

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Abstract

How do countries adjust their foreign policy when a rising power becomes their leading trading partner? We argue that a sufficiently salient and lasting change in trade rankings can shape diplomatic positioning in politically relevant fora, such as the United Nations General Assembly. To study the phenomenon, we focus on Brazil and China's 2009 ranking shift, when China surpassed the United States as Brazil's largest export destination, using synthetic Difference-in-Differences to estimate the causal effect of the change on Brazil's voting at the UNGA. The paper shows evidence that Brazilian policymakers invoked China's new position to justify greater proximity between the countries, converging voting particularly on human rights issues. Relative to the counterfactual, the estimated reduction in bilateral voting distance is equivalent to 42% of the median distance before 2009. To assess whether this pattern extends beyond Brazil, we estimate a latent factor model using data from a panel of countries where China became the leading trading partner between 2000 and 2022. The estimates point in the same direction, although the effects are smaller. These findings suggest that publicly acknowledged changes in economic rank can support diplomatic adjustments in multilateral institutions, with implications for U.S.–China rivalry as their relative commercial positions change.

1 Introduction

“China overtakes US as Brazil’s top trade partner.” That was a headline in many Brazilian newspapers in 2009 (A. Rodrigues 2009). The BBC ran a similar headline in 2021, when China surpassed the United States as the EU’s biggest trading partner (BBC News 2021). During a high-profile trip to Beijing with an unusually large business delegation, President Lula da Silva invoked the milestone by noting that China was Brazil’s largest export destination (Presidência da República Federativa do Brasil 2009).

Export statistics are updated monthly, and international trade journalists, diplomats, and policymakers follow them closely, so there is no new information being transmitted when one partner moves up the ladder of trade hierarchy. And yet, public discourse revolves around such categorical milestones. Why can a milestone, such as China becoming the number-one trade partner, matter politically despite adding little new information about the economic trend itself?

If everyone is perfectly rational, redundant information should not matter. Most of the literature on the effects of interdependence implicitly or explicitly assumes this hyperrationalist perspective and studies only the effects of trade flows (Flores-Macías and Kreps 2013; Urdinez et al. 2016; Kastner and Pearson 2021). Therefore, foreign-policy alignment should move gradually with trade exposure and economic interdependence in general. There is no expectation that discrete changes in economic or trade status will produce any effect on the foreign policy of countries.

Domestic political accounts of foreign policy, on the other hand, can conceivably attribute foreign-policy change to discrete changes, but only to changes such as new leadership ideology or political coalition (Neto 2011; Neto and Malamud 2015; P. Rodrigues, Urdinez, and De Oliveira 2019; Luis L. Schenoni et al. 2022).

A different concern for the study of the effect of status change is reverse causality, since politically aligned countries may deepen economic ties with one another, making China’s

rise in the trade hierarchy a consequence rather than a cause of prior diplomatic affinity (Gowa 1995; Davis and Pratt 2021; Strüver 2016). If alignment reflects only accumulated exposure, domestic political reorientation, or prior diplomatic affinity, however, no specific symbolic milestone, such as becoming a top trade partner, should matter.

I argue that such milestones matter because they mark trade-based status gains. The argument builds on research that treats status as socially recognized standing within international hierarchies, clubs, and local status orders (Paul, Larson, and Wohlforth 2014; Wolf 2011, 2019; Duque 2018; Renshon 2017; Götz 2021; MacDonald and Parent 2021; Røren 2024, 2025). By trade-based status, I mean the recognized standing of a foreign power within a country's hierarchy of economically consequential relationships. Trade volume is continuous, but status is categorical: a partner can move from being important to being understood as central. Once that reclassification becomes public, the relationship is no longer merely larger than before. It becomes easier for political actors to invoke as a national priority, to defend as strategically consequential, and to use as a justification for diplomatic adjustment.

Much of the China and rising-powers branch of this literature asks how rising states seek recognition, major-power status, or institutional standing, and how misrecognition can produce contestation or revisionism (Deng 2008; Larson and Shevchenko 2010; Ward 2017; Murray 2018; Mukherjee 2022). This argument relocates status from the ambitions of the rising power to the recognition practices of states. China's trade-based status gain occurs when another country publicly recategorizes China within its own hierarchy of external economic relationships – from an important partner to a central one. The mechanism is therefore status-theoretic, with Brazil as the audience and status-conferring actor.

The argument links US-China competition to the recognition practices of third countries. When China overtakes the United States in a national trade hierarchy, its commercial rise can become a public basis for selective diplomatic accommodation. Multilateral voting provides an arena in which countries such as Brazil can adjust their positions toward China while retaining flexibility in other areas of foreign policy. This perspective locates one possible consequence of China's rise for the US-led international order in changes in diplomatic

support within existing institutions.

Brazil is the strongest case for the theory. First, China displaced the United States, a politically salient incumbent, hegemonic benchmark, and the most important trade partner of Brazil for almost 80 years. Second, the rank reversal was publicly visible. Third, the Brazilian press allows the attention implication to be measured. The case is also substantively important because Lula-era Brazilian foreign policy is often described through autonomy, South-South activism, multipolarity, and Brazil's triangular position between the United States and China (Neto 2011; Neto and Malamud 2015; P. Rodrigues, Urdinez, and De Oliveira 2019; Luis L. Schenoni et al. 2022; Guilhon-Albuquerque 2014; Luis L. Schenoni and Leiva 2021; Brun and Covarrubias 2024; Coutinho and Rodriguez 2024).

To estimate the Brazilian foreign-policy alignment pattern, I use synthetic difference-in-differences (SDiD) on annual UNGA ideal-point distance to China, with 2009 marking China's rise to the largest Brazilian export destination. UNGA voting is a standard measure to study alignment with China and other powers, linking votes to bilateral ties, ideology, sanctions, aid, Belt and Road membership, arms transfers, or Chinese economic returns (Potrafke 2009; Dreher and Jensen 2013; Strüver 2016; Yan and Zhou 2021; Garcia-Herrero, Storella, and Weil 2024; Steinert and Weyrauch 2024; He, Zheng, and Chen 2025; Lektzian and Biglaiser 2023).

In the preferred specification, the estimated reduced-form effect of entry into the new trade-rank condition is a reduction of 0.273 ideal-point units in Brazil's distance to China relative to its synthetic counterfactual, equivalent to 42.2 percent of its pre-treatment mean, with a one-sided placebo-rank p-value of 0.031.

To assess whether a compatible directional pattern appears beyond Brazil and to check the narrower threat posed by explanations tied specifically to Brazil's 2009 calendar year, I extend the analysis to a cross-country panel in which China enters and holds the top goods-export destination position. The cross-country estimates are smaller in magnitude, consistent with a more heterogeneous sample, and point in the same direction as the Brazilian case. The pooled panel estimate is -0.101 (p-value = 0.010) and is stable across duration thresholds and sample restrictions (p-value between 0.003 and 0.019). The panel

evidence identifies a directional pattern associated with entry into the goods-only rank condition; the public-status mechanism is measured directly only in the Brazilian case.

The paper's contribution is to show that economic status matters and impacts foreign policy. Existing work usually treats trade exposure as a smooth source of influence. I argue that accumulated trade growth can become politically consequential when it crosses a durable, publicly legible rank threshold. It is particularly likely when a great power, such as China, holds the new status. In the case of Brazil, China's rise to the top export destination position made an already expanding commercial relationship available in public and official language as evidence of China's new centrality. The mechanism evidence shows that the public cue was available and used by policymakers in their political discourse, working as a focal point.

The next section develops the status-threshold argument and derives observable implications. I then present the Brazil SDiD design and timing diagnostics, followed by issue-area and media evidence on the mechanism. The final empirical section evaluates whether durable China-top goods-export status is associated with similar movement in a broader cross-country panel.

2 Theory and Hypotheses

A trade-based status shift differs from smooth growth in economic interdependence because it changes the category through which a foreign power is understood. Actors can observe trade shares, but political attention rarely follows continuous movements one percentage point at a time. It also organizes around coarse public labels: largest export market, number-one partner, top-ranked export destination. These labels simplify complex economic relationships and help journalists, politicians, organized interests, and diplomats coordinate attention (Bordalo, Gennaioli, and Shleifer 2022; Conlon 2025; Enke 2024; Graeber, Roth, and Sammon 2025). It works as a focal point (Schelling 1960).

The cue should matter most when the new status also displaces a politically prominent incumbent. If a rising major power overtakes a minor partner, the event may remain a

commercial fact with limited political resonance. If it overtakes the hegemonic incumbent, the same threshold takes on broader political meaning. It can be read as a visible loss of standing for the incumbent and as a public marker of the challenger's rise. Brazil falls squarely inside this high-salience condition: China became Brazil's largest export destination in 2009, displaced the United States, and contemporary coverage frequently described the event in broader top-partner language.

The mechanism has two steps. Firstly, the status cue should increase attention. Media coverage should make the challenger and the bilateral trade relationship more visible after the threshold is crossed.

Secondly, the cue should affect policy through justification. Once that power is publicly understood as a central economic partner, executives and diplomats can frame limited movement toward it as pragmatic recognition of the country's economic hierarchy rather than as ideological concession or opportunistic bandwagoning.

This attribution of symbolic status between two countries is a standard movement in foreign policy. Leaders in Canada refers to themselves as middle powers (Chapnick 1999). Churchill famously called the US-UK relationship a special one (Reynolds 1985). Mitterrand used "couple franco-allemand" to promote the Europe Union (Krotz and Schild 2013). My argument is that trade status works in a similar fashion. The number-one threshold matters because it can reclassify a rising power from one important commercial partner among several into the country's central economic partner.

The status change is a step function. However, the actual foreign policy change can be gradual because UNGA positions are embedded in prior votes, bureaucratic routines, coalition commitments, and reputational constraints.

The justification mechanism also implies a durability condition. The rank reversal is not expected to reshape foreign policy through a single decision at the moment China becomes number one. Rather, it creates a public category that officials can invoke repeatedly across a sequence of selective adjustments. When China remains the largest export destination, presidents, ministers, diplomats, and organized interests can treat its centrality as a stable fact of the national economic hierarchy and use it to justify incremental diplomatic move-

ment. A one-year China-top episode may attract attention, but it is a weaker treatment regime: it does not provide a durable basis for repeated public justification, bureaucratic recalibration, or cumulative foreign-policy adaptation.

2.1 From Attention to Selective Diplomatic Alignment

Trade-based status changes the terms on which selective accommodation can be justified. Some foreign-policy arenas are especially suitable for this kind of adjustment: they are visible to foreign governments and diplomatic audiences, materially less costly than treaties or trade policy, and still capable of generating reputational exposure. In such arenas, governments can signal movement toward a newly central partner while preserving flexibility.

When a foreign power's rise to the top export-destination position is publicly recognized as evidence of centrality in the country's trade hierarchy, policymakers can frame limited convergence with that power as pragmatic recognition of economic importance rather than as ideological concession or opportunistic bandwagoning.

The domestic pathway works through justification. Public recognition of the partner's new standing changes what diplomats and executives can plausibly defend. Adjustment toward that partner becomes easier to present as alignment with national economic interests, especially in diplomatic settings where positions are visible internationally but relatively low-cost domestically.

This logic implies selective convergence. The mechanism should be most informative in issue areas where the country and the newly elevated partner previously differed and where movement is not costless. In domains tied to prior reputational commitments, adjustment toward the newly central partner requires a stronger rationale than in areas where the two countries already agree. Trade-based status supplies such a rationale by making the partner's economic centrality publicly available as a justification for diplomatic accommodation.

The main theoretical expectation is therefore that when a rising major power becomes a country's largest export destination and that milestone becomes a public trade-status cue,

the country's foreign policy should move closer to that power relative to its counterfactual path. The effect should be easiest to observe when the status gain displaces a politically prominent incumbent, especially a hegemonic benchmark such as the United States. The theory also implies an attention pattern: media coverage of the rising power and of the bilateral economic relationship should increase around the status shift.

3 Data and Design

The theoretical concept of interest is the rising power obtaining the status of top trade partner of a country. However, public status language varies in what counts as a top trade partner and in how it is described. Officials and journalists may describe China as the largest trading partner, main commercial partner, or top export market, for instance. Countries also value different things as a matter of status: largest flow of trade (exports plus imports) is what matters for some countries. For others, it is largest total exports (goods and services), or largest goods exports.

For the argument advanced in the article, what matters is the status change. Export-destination rank operationalizes the trade-based status shift. But since I have more information about Brazil than about other countries, I explain the differences in how I operationalize the treatment in the SDiD model and the cross-country panel regression.

3.1 SDiD Design

In the design in which Brazil is the only treated country, the treatment is given by an export-destination rank in goods trade – China becoming number one in that rank. In Brazil, public and official language tracks that rank: the 2009 coverage announcing that China had overtaken the United States as the country's largest trading partner was reporting precisely that change.

The primary outcome is absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China, based on the annual ideal-point estimates of Bailey, Strezhnev, and Voeten (2017). Lower values indicate convergence toward China. This measure is preferable to raw annual agreement shares

for the main design because it is less sensitive to changes in the UNGA agenda over time. I use resolution-level agreement diagnostics only to interpret where convergence appears strongest. As a measurement-robustness check, the appendix re-estimates the main specifications using ideal points estimated by Fjelstul, Hug, and Kilby (2026), which are slightly different from Bailey, Strezhnev, and Voeten (2017) and based on another sample of resolution-related votes.

For Brazil, the treatment indicator equals one from 2009 onward, the first year China became Brazil's largest export destination. SDiD estimates Brazil's average post-2009 gap relative to a weighted synthetic counterfactual, using pre-treatment information to construct unit and time weights (Arkhangelsky et al. 2021). The design is reduced-form. Its credibility rests on pre-treatment fit, rank-versus-volume timing tests, donor-pool sensitivity, and outcome robustness.

The SDiD panel combines UNGA ideal points with trade, macroeconomic, power, geographic, institutional, and trade-agreement variables. The complete panel covers 96 countries and 19 Brazil years for the main SDiD window (1997-2015). The preferred estimator uses no covariates: the counterfactual is built from pre-treatment outcomes together with the SDiD unit and time weights. Time-varying variables enter only comparison specifications. Trade data come from the International Trade and Production Database for Estimation (Borchert et al. 2021). The ITPD-E `trade` variable is measured in millions of current US dollars, and export-destination ranks are computed from exporter-importer flows.

The Brazil variables enter the design in three groups. The outcome is Brazil's annual absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China; the treatment is an indicator for years after China becomes Brazil's largest export destination; and observed country characteristics are used for diagnostics and comparison specifications. The preferred counterfactual is driven by pre-treatment outcomes and SDiD unit and time weights, not by effective covariate adjustment. Contemporaneous trade, macroeconomic, power, ideology, and institutional measures remain available for comparisons but are not preferred because their post-2009 values may be mediators or outcomes of the same shocks.

The panel regression uses the same outcome but constructs treatment separately from

goods-only export-destination ranks and a status-current risk set. Table 1 summarizes the full country-year panel from which the Brazil specifications are constructed.

Table 1: Descriptive statistics for the country-year panel used in the Brazil SDiD design.

Variable	N	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Treatment	1824	0.00	0.06	0.00	1.00
UNGA distance to China	1824	0.91	0.80	0.00	4.22
UNGA distance to US	1824	2.65	0.92	0.00	5.06
Geographic distance to US	1824	0.00	0.50	-1.14	1.11
Trade share with China	1824	-0.01	0.49	-0.36	4.96
Trade share with US	1824	0.00	0.50	-0.41	1.87
Power index	1824	0.00	0.50	-0.12	5.01
Power gap to US	1824	0.03	0.49	-3.90	0.43
GDP per capita	1824	-0.00	0.50	-0.37	2.81
Exchange rate	1824	-0.00	0.49	-0.15	6.82
HoG left ideology	1824	0.40	0.49	0.00	1.00
Current account	1824	0.00	0.50	-3.24	2.56
Government deficit	1824	0.01	0.50	-6.59	3.33
Parliamentary system	1824	0.39	0.49	0.00	1.00
Military executive	1824	0.11	0.31	0.00	1.00
US trade agreement	1824	0.09	0.28	0.00	1.00

Note:

Country-year variables from the SDiD analytic panel; continuous covariates are rescaled in the estimation data, UNGA distances are ideal-point distances, and treatment is binary. Window: 1997-2015 SDiD analytic panel. Observations include Brazil and donor countries used to construct the synthetic counterfactual. The treatment mean is small because only Brazil is treated after 2009. Covariate summaries describe the full analytic panel; the preferred estimate uses none of them.

3.2 Identification Strategy

I want to estimate the causal effect of a country's rise in China's trade hierarchy on its foreign policy. The main direct challenge to causal identification is differentiating it from a continuous foreign-policy approximation as exposure to trade with China increases over

time. Besides that, countries may move closer to China due to changes in domestic political coalitions or foreign-policy doctrine reorientation that coincide in timing with the treatment, because governments already inclined toward China deepen commercial ties before the rank reversal occurs, or due to any other confounding variable.

To address these issues, I use Synthetic Difference-in-Differences (SDiD). Like the Synthetic Control Method (SCM), it constructs a weighted counterfactual from a donor pool to estimate the causal effect, using weights to approximate the counterfactual in ways that DiD cannot. Unlike the SCM and similar to the DiD, it estimates unit fixed effects, but with different weights. This combines both methods into a single one. As a result, violations of (unweighted average) parallel trends do not mean violations of weighted parallel trends. And, unique to the method, it weights the time periods, choosing the ones most comparable pre- and post-treatment. In other words, the weights pool observations to reduce bias in a latent factor model, even when global parallel trends are not valid. Arkhangelsky et al. (2021) show SDiD is consistent under this latent factor model when weights converge adequately.

The SDiD design estimates the reduced-form effect of entry into this trade-rank condition on UNGA distance to China.

The preferred specification uses no covariates because time-varying post-2009 values may induce post-treatment bias. A model specification with time-varying variables uses trade, power, ideology, macroeconomic stress, and institutional variables to control for potential confounding. The similarity of the estimates indicates low sensitivity to post-treatment adjustment, suggesting the results are not driven by the covariates. Commodity composition and price interactions are also treated as robustness or mechanism diagnostics, especially because the 2008–2009 interaction includes the first treated year.

To compute the uncertainty of estimates, I use a one-sided placebo-in-space rank of the Brazil estimate within the distribution of placebo estimates obtained by reassigning treatment to each unit from the donor pool. For robustness, I also report the standard error calculated from the normal approximation native to the SDiD estimator. I use a one-sided hypothesis test, since the theory is directional (a treated unit should move its ideal point

toward China), and report the two-sided test as a conservative sensitivity assessment.

Two features of rank-based inference with a single treated unit are noteworthy. First, with only 96 countries, the most extreme possible result would be Brazil having the largest effect, yielding a p-value floor of approximately 0.010. Second, the two-sided absolute rank counts large placebo effects of either sign against Brazil, including positive placebo effects that do not represent the error relevant to a directional hypothesis. I apply the same convention throughout the paper to every placebo-based diagnostic.

3.3 Cross-Country Regression

Notwithstanding my best effort to address potential rival explanations for the observed reduced-form causal effect of the change in 2009, there is only so much one can do with a single treated case. Thus, I also consider a broader panel of countries in which China became the number-one export destination, estimated with a latent interactive fixed-effects regression (Liu, Wang, and Xu 2024). Interactive fixed effects allow countries to load differently on common latent shocks. Treated countries enter China-top status in different years, so a Brazil-specific 2009 shock cannot mechanically generate the pooled result.

This approach, however, faces some challenges that must be addressed or at least recognized. The conceptual treatment, as mentioned, is status, not the rank. However, for each country what matters is not necessarily being the top trade destination in goods exports. Elsewhere the status cue may track aggregate flows, services exports, or even imports. It all depends on what each country considers more important. It is understandable that a service-oriented country like Malta will weight service trade more than a country like Brazil, where goods exports are what matters.

To better understand variation in the media coverage on this, a supplemental source audit in the appendix uses displaced-incumbent coverage to check evidence of coverage in other countries. Australia illustrates a metric distinction. The *Australian Financial Review* reported on 9 November 2009 that China was Australia's largest aggregate trading partner, combining exports and imports of goods and services. The current goods-only annual panel codes Australia's first qualifying China-top goods-export year as 2009, after Japan

held the top goods-export rank in 2008. The AFR item therefore documents broad-metric salience during the same annual treatment window; it does not establish that a strict goods-export cue preceded the 2009 treatment. This mismatch introduces measurement error into the cross-country treatment indicator. If this error is random and nondifferential with respect to potential voting outcomes and their trends, I would expect attenuation toward zero and would therefore interpret the estimated magnitude as conservative under that assumption.

For the cross-country evidence beyond Brazil, the treated sample is restricted to what I call “durable periods” of China-top status. A durable period is one in which China is the largest goods-export destination for at least five consecutive observed years, after an observed prior year in which China was not number one.

Since I am interested in a rising power becoming number one, specifically China, I restrict the treatment to years in or after 2000, when it is more plausible that China was seen as a rising power and the status cue would trigger a foreign policy change.

Countries that never reach China-top goods-export status remain controls. I do allow for a country to switch into and out of treatment. Such cases remain in the sample. For treated countries, the main risk set keeps clean pre-entry non-China-top years and qualifying treated years, while excluding post-exit off-status years and short China-top episodes. This operationalization matches the salience logic more closely than either a one-year entry definition or an absorbing treatment rule: the theory expects political visibility, bureaucratic learning, and diplomatic adaptation to be clearer when the new trade hierarchy persists and is currently true. I compute partner ranks from ITPD-E goods sectors only, excluding services before ranks are constructed. I estimate this panel with the `fect` implementation and refer to it as the IFE specification below. The appendix reports duration-threshold and risk-set robustness checks.

4 Brazil SDiD Evidence

The Brazilian analysis estimates the average post-2009 reduced-form effect of China's entry into the top export-destination position on Brazil's UNGA ideal-point distance to China. It asks whether Brazil moved closer to China than a synthetic counterfactual after the 2009 rank reversal.

Figure 1 shows the timing of the rank threshold. China's export share rose before 2009, but China became the top-ranked export destination only in 2009. The signed margin over the relevant competitor also changes sign at that threshold.

Figure 2 presents the preferred SDiD fit, estimated without covariates. The estimated reduced-form effect of entry into the trade-rank condition is negative: the ATT is -0.273 ideal-point units. Substantively, this is a reduction equivalent to 1.35 standard deviations of Brazil's annual pre-treatment distance to China.

The placebo-based SE is 0.131, and the conventional two-sided normal-approximation p-value is 0.037 with a 95 percent interval [-0.529, -0.017]. Because the theory predicts convergence, the directionally aligned placebo-in-space rank is 3/96 ($p = 0.031$); the conservative two-sided absolute rank is 7/96 ($p = 0.073$). I report both rather than treating either convention as the sole inferential benchmark. Interpreting these finite-sample ranks as p-values requires placebo assignments to be sufficiently comparable to Brazil; the appendix therefore discloses donor exposure and pre-fit sensitivity. Relative to Brazil's pre-treatment mean distance (0.647), the ATT corresponds to a 42.2 percent reduction. Appendix Figure 8 shows that China is comparatively stable, so most of the reduction in absolute distance comes from movement in Brazil's position.

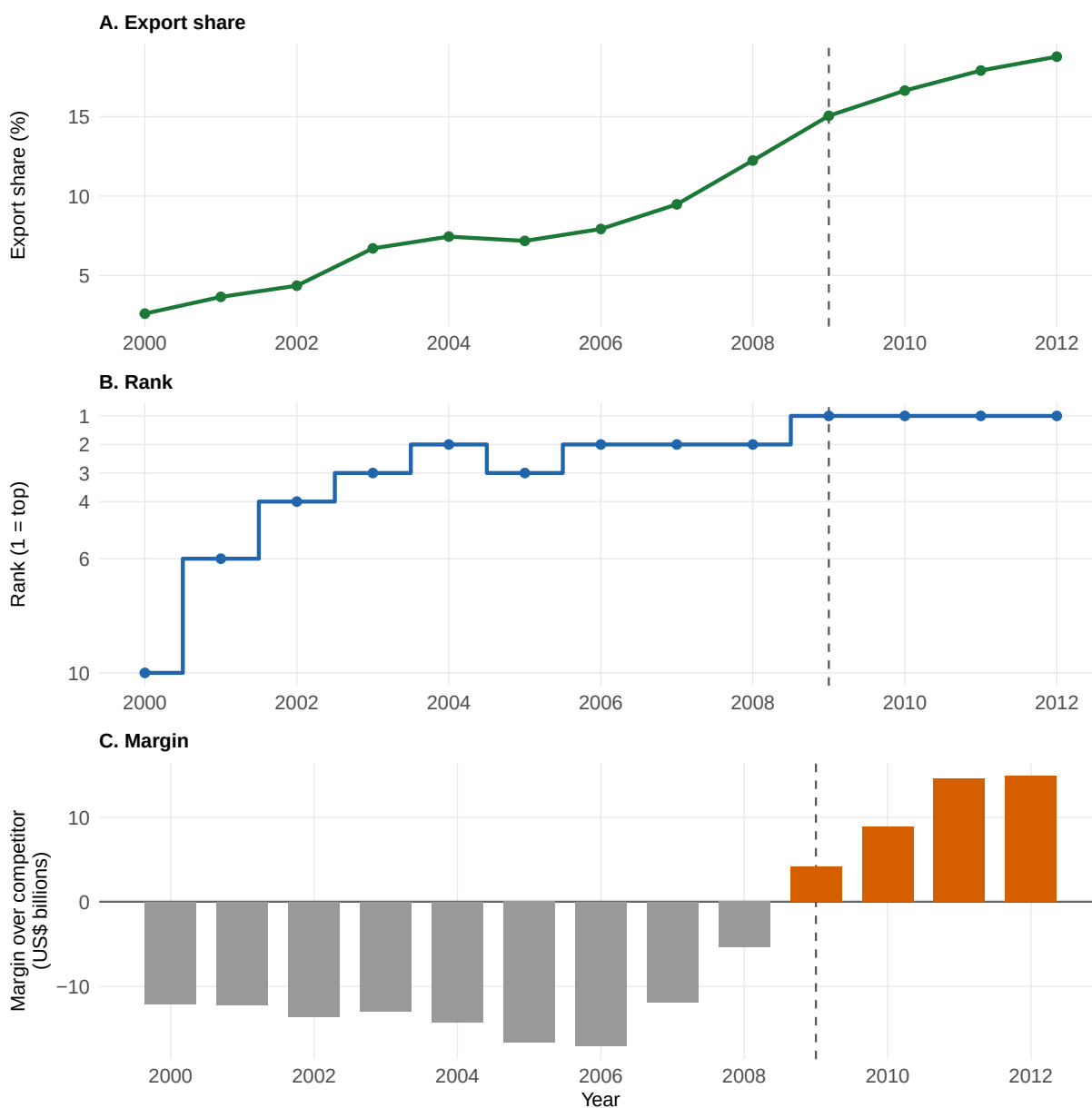


Figure 1: Brazil rank-versus-volume diagnostic for China's export-destination status. Panels show China's export share, ordinal rank, and signed margin over the relevant competitor. The dashed line marks the 2009 rank reversal. Note: Export share in percent; ordinal rank; export-value margin in current USD billions. Window: 2000-2012 annual Brazil series.

Preferred specification, estimated without covariates

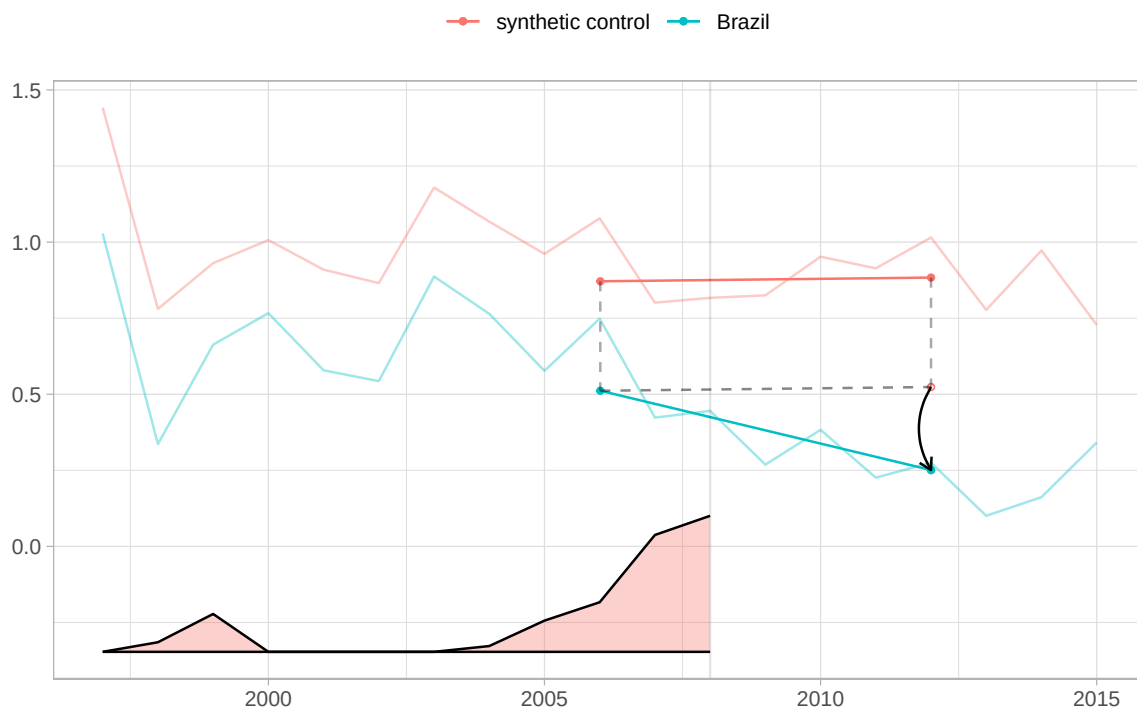


Figure 2: Preferred SDiD fit for Brazil and its synthetic comparison, estimated without covariates. Lower values indicate convergence toward China; the post-treatment gap is the average post-2009 reduced-form estimate. Note: Absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China. SE: placebo-based SE with 20,000 replications; p-values reported in the text and table. Window: 1997-2015 annual Brazil series.

Figure 3 shows the placebo-in-space distribution behind that inference. Brazil sits in the left tail of the estimates obtained by reassigning treatment to each donor in turn.

Table 2 summarizes the diagnostic package behind the preferred Brazil SDiD estimate. The top five donors are Georgia 3.1%, Singapore 2.9%, Chad 2.8%, Guatemala 2.7%, Paraguay 2.7%, and the complete donor pool, along with pre-treatment time weights and sensitivity diagnostics based on donor-deletion and window tests, appears in Appendix Tables 9, 10, 14, and 15.

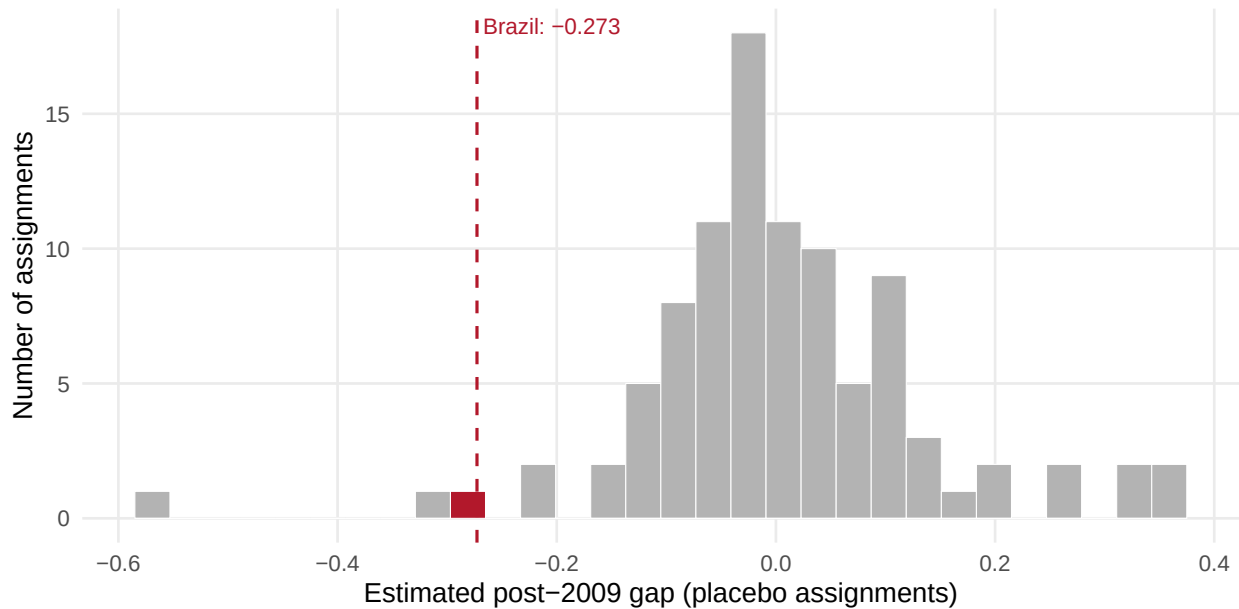


Figure 3: Distribution of placebo-in-space estimates across the 95 donor assignments, with Brazil marked. Brazil's estimate is the 3rd most negative of 96 assignments (directional $p = 0.031$); the two-sided absolute rank is 7/96 ($p = 0.073$). Negative values indicate convergence toward China. Note: Estimated post-2009 gap in absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China. Window: 1997-2015 annual SDiD panel.

Table 2: Brazil SDiD diagnostics: fit, placebo inference, and sensitivity. Preferred estimate: -0.273 ideal-point units (1997–2015; treatment begins in 2009).

Measure	Result
A. Donor weights: concentration of the comparison group	
Number of donors	95
Largest donor weight	3.1%
Combined weight of the five largest donors	14.4%
B. Pre-treatment fit: prediction error after adjusting levels	
Pre-treatment prediction error (RMSPE)	0.058
Post-treatment / pre-treatment RMSPE	5.54
Brazil's pre-treatment mean distance to China	0.647
C. Placebo inference: Brazil's rank among all assignments	
Directional rank (convergence toward China)	3/96 ($p = 0.031$)
Two-sided rank (absolute effect size)	7/96 ($p = 0.073$)
D. Donor sensitivity: exclusions and exposure to China	
Largest change when dropping one of the top ten donors	3.6%
Estimate after dropping all ten highest-weight donors	-0.268
Weight on high-weight donors with China in their top two	10.2%
E. Windows and timing: stability of the point estimate	
Windows with a negative estimate (including preferred)	7 of 7
Range of estimates across windows	-0.320 to -0.256
2004 onset: China rank 2 (post-period: 2004–2008)	-0.109
2009 onset: China rank 2 (post-period: 2009–2015)	-0.273

Table 3 reports the preferred Brazil SDiD estimate alongside four comparisons. Column (1) uses no covariates and is preferred because it avoids conditioning the counterfactual on variables observed after 2009. Column (2) restores the full contemporaneous covariate matrix; column (3) removes institutional variables but retains the other contemporaneous measures; column (4) changes the donor pool to Latin America using the contemporaneous matrix; and column (5) applies the preferred no-covariate specification to that regional pool, which makes it the column comparable with (1). All five estimates are negative, but columns (2)–(4) are sensitivity checks rather than alternative candidates for the main specification.

One may wonder whether a synthetic control built from donors all over the world is a good counterfactual for Brazil. Column (5) re-estimates the preferred specification on a donor pool restricted to Latin American countries. The estimated effect is larger in absolute terms, -0.326 against -0.273 in the global pool, and Brazil is the 2nd most negative of 20 assignments in the directional placebo comparison ($p = 0.100$). The regional pool is small, which limits what either inference convention can show: with 20 units the rank test cannot fall below 0.050 however extreme Brazil is, and the placebo standard error rises from 0.131 to 0.207, so the normal-approximation interval includes zero. Figure 11 reports the regional fit.

Table 3: Brazil SDiD estimates across main and robustness specifications.

	(1) Preferred: no covariates	(2) Current covariates	(3) No institutions	(4) Latin America, covariates	(5) Latin America, none
ATT	-0.273** (0.131)	-0.268* (0.143)	-0.269* (0.143)	-0.408** (0.207)	-0.326 (0.207)
<i>Covariates:</i>					
Trade share China		✓	✓	✓	
Trade share US		✓	✓	✓	
Power index (GPI)		✓	✓	✓	
Power gap to US		✓	✓	✓	
Per-capita income		✓	✓	✓	
Exchange rate		✓	✓	✓	
Geographic distance to US		✓	✓	✓	
HoG left ideology		✓	✓	✓	
Current account (% GDP)		✓	✓	✓	
Gov. deficit (% GDP)		✓	✓	✓	
Parliamentary system		✓		✓	
Military executive		✓		✓	
US trade agreement		✓		✓	
Country-years	1,824	1,824	1,824	380	380
Donor countries	95	95	95	19	19
Donor pool	Global	Global	Global	Latin America	Latin America
Time window	1997-2015	1997-2015	1997-2015	1997-2015	1997-2015

Note:

The outcome is absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China; ATT is the estimated average causal effect on Brazil after 2009, so negative values mean convergence. ATTs are reported with three decimals. Placebo-based SEs are in parentheses (20,000 replications for columns (1) and (5), which use the preferred no-covariate specification; 5,000 for comparison columns (2)-(4)). Stars use two-sided normal-approximation p-values based on placebo SEs: * $p < 0.10$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Checkmarks show included covariate groups. Donor counts exclude Brazil. Column (1) uses no covariates, so its covariate cells are left blank. Columns (2)-(4) use contemporaneous covariates and are comparisons. Column (5) applies the preferred no-covariate specification to the Latin American donor pool, so it is the column comparable with (1); its directional placebo rank is 2/20 ($p = 0.100$), against a floor of 0.050 imposed by the size of the regional pool. For column (1), the directional rank is 3/96 ($p = 0.031$) and the bilateral absolute rank is 7/96 ($p = 0.073$).

The rank interpretation requires more than showing that trade with China was increasing. Brazil's exports to China grew before 2009, including years in which China rose in the export hierarchy but did not become number one. Table 4 therefore reports outcome-path timing falsifications without covariates: using no covariates prevents variables measured after the early pseudo-onsets from entering those comparisons. The 2003, 2004, and 2005 estimates are smaller than the 2009 rank-one estimate; 2004 is especially useful because China first reaches rank 2 but is still not Brazil's largest export destination. The 2012 row probes a later break after China had already become the top destination. These are point-estimate diagnostics rather than additional tests with separately recomputed placebo inference.

The same timing logic addresses the main Brazilian political confounder. President Lula da Silva took office in 2003 and pursued a more explicit South-South foreign-policy agenda, a shift emphasized in work on Brazilian autonomy, presidential foreign policy, and international engagement (Neto 2011; Mourón and Urdinez 2014; Neto and Malamud 2015; P. Rodrigues, Urdinez, and De Oliveira 2019; Luis L. Schenoni et al. 2022). If that ideological shift were sufficient to explain Brazil-China UNGA convergence, the pseudo-treatment years in 2003 or 2005 should already show comparable movement. They do not. The cross-country panel also estimates the rank-threshold pattern across countries with different political systems and leadership profiles, which reduces the concern that the Brazil estimate is only a Lula-period artifact.

The main rival explanation for the proposed effect of a discrete status change is that Brazil's estimated convergence simply reflects a continuous increase in its export dependence on China. Under this account, UNGA alignment should respond smoothly to the degree of trade exposure to China. The pattern shown in Figure 1 is compatible with this possibility: Brazil's export exposure increased well before 2009, raising the concern that nothing distinctive occurred at the rank-one threshold and that the estimated effect instead reflects Brazil's growing commercial ties with China.

To assess this possibility, I relate each donor country's placebo-in-space pseudo-ATT to the change in its export share directed to China. By construction, the donor pool excludes countries in which China became the largest goods-export destination during the 1997–2015 estimation window. These countries therefore provide variation in trade exposure below the rank-one threshold. If continuous exposure drives alignment, donors experiencing larger increases in exposure should exhibit more negative pseudo-ATTs – that is, greater convergence toward China. A flat or positive relationship would instead weaken this rival explanation, although it would not by itself establish that status is the operative mechanism.

Figure 4 provides little support for the continuous-exposure account. Panel A measures exposure using goods trade, matching the sectoral definition used to assign treatment, while Panel B uses all-sector trade, including both goods and services. The relationship

is essentially flat under both measures. The OLS slopes are 0.0002 and 0.0007 per percentage point, respectively, while the corresponding Spearman correlations are 0.034 and 0.037. Under either measure, Brazil's ATT is also more negative than those of 23 of the 24 donors in the highest quartile of exposure growth. These patterns do not rule out a role for continuous export dependence, nor do they identify a discontinuity at the rank threshold itself, but they make it less plausible that Brazil's result is driven simply by rising trade exposure to China.

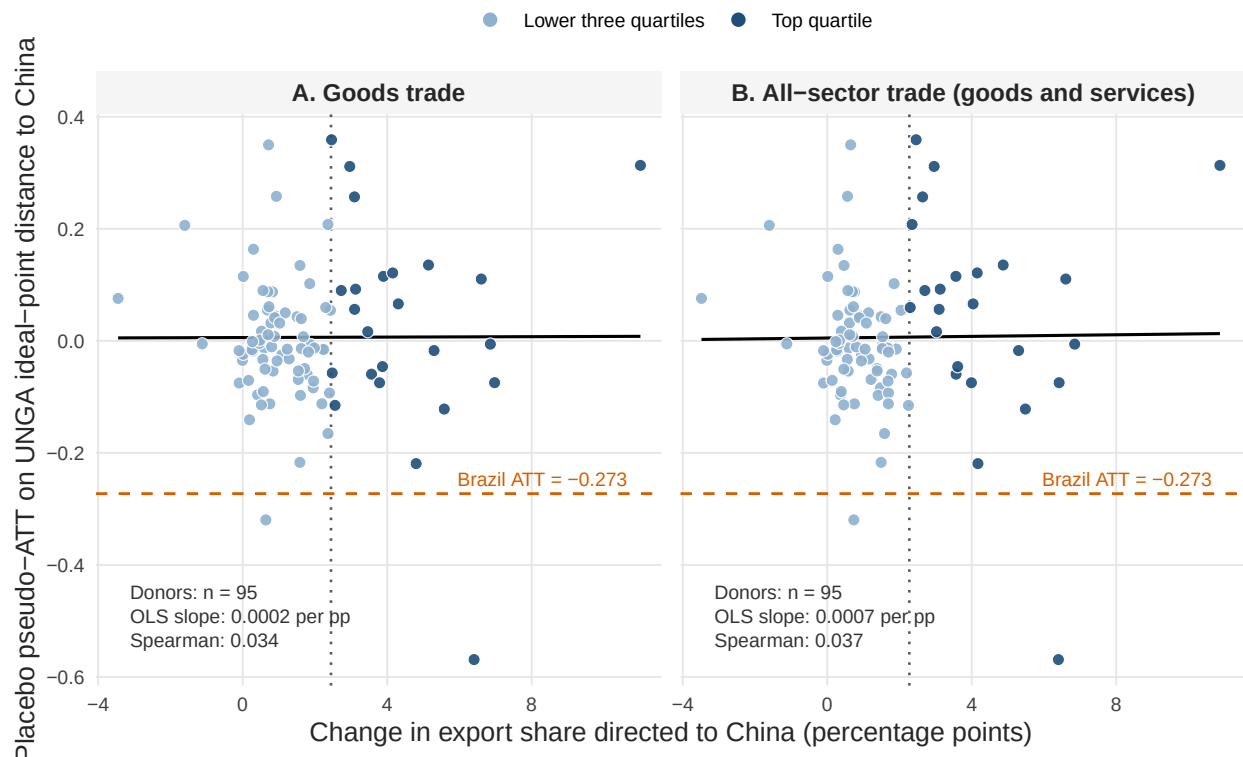


Figure 4: Trade-exposure dose and placebo-in-space pseudo-ATTs among 95 donor countries. Each donor is assigned the same 2009 pseudo-treatment, and dose is the difference between its mean annual export share directed to China in 2009–2015 and 1997–2008. Panel A measures goods trade; Panel B measures all-sector trade, including goods and services. Negative pseudo-ATTs indicate convergence toward China. Dark points identify donors in the top quartile of dose, vertical dotted lines mark the corresponding cutoffs, and black lines are descriptive OLS fits. The orange dashed horizontal line marks Brazil's ATT of -0.273; Brazil has no dose coordinate and therefore does not enter either fit. No donor had China as its largest goods-export destination during 1997–2015, so the figure shows only the dose gradient below the rank-one threshold and does not identify a discontinuity at that threshold. Donor pseudo-ATTs are estimated from overlapping pools, so no standard error is reported for either slope.

A remaining concern is that 2009 bundled the Brazilian rank reversal with other contemporaneous shocks, including the global financial crisis, the BRICS/G20 moment, and the commodity cycle. Table 5 uses a measure built from external goods exports only to address this critique. Brazil's 2004–2008 primary-goods share is 29.04 percent, composed of 11.25 percent Agriculture and 17.79 percent Mining and Energy. The preferred ATT is -0.273; adding primary composition and its 2008–2009 interaction yields -0.285. Composition, decomposition, global-price, and prior-China-exposure specifications remain in a narrow negative range. The 2008–2009 interactions are robustness or mechanism diagnostics, not alternative total-effect estimates, because 2009 is the first treated year and the interaction may absorb part of the mechanism. Stability across these measures does not isolate the rank cue experimentally from every 2009 political shock, but it reduces the narrower concern that the preferred estimate is an artifact of post-treatment controls or omitted pre-2009 commodity composition.

The cross-country panel below is a broader scope check, not the main answer to the Brazil-specific demand-shock critique. Brazil is included in the goods-only cross-country sample, but the panel aligns countries by their own China-top goods-export entry years. A Brazil-specific 2009 confounder cannot mechanically generate an average event-time effect across countries treated in different calendar years. For such an explanation to account for both the Brazil estimate and the cross-country result, the omitted force would need to coincide with durable China-top entry across countries, affect UNGA distance to China in the same direction, and remain outside the latent factors captured by the interactive fixed-effects specification. It would also need to be strongly enough associated with both treatment timing and the outcome to overturn estimates that are stable across the Brazil timing tests, donor-pool checks, and the cross-country duration and risk-set checks.

Table 4: Brazil SDiD rank-versus-volume timing diagnostics without covariates.

Timing year	Test role	China rank	Export share (%)	Margin (USD bn)	ATT	Inference
2003	Growth/lower-rank promotion	3	6.7	-12.9	-0.064	Point estimate only; no covariates
2004	China rank-2 threshold	2	7.4	-14.2	-0.109	Point estimate only; no covariates
2005	Rapid growth without rank 1	3	7.2	-16.7	-0.099	Point estimate only; no covariates
2009	Actual rank-1 reversal	1	15.1	4.1	-0.273	Point estimate only; no covariates
2012	Later-break falsification	1	18.8	14.9	-0.100	Point estimate only; no covariates

Note:

Outcome is absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China; ATT is the estimated causal effect on Brazil after the nominal onset, so negative values mean convergence; export margins are current USD billions. Window: 2003-2005 timing tests end in 2008; 2012 is a later-break falsification using data through 2016. All rows are no-covariate point-estimate diagnostics. The preferred 2009 estimate and its inference are reported separately in the main specification.

Table 5: Brazil SDiD estimates under corrected predetermined commodity and China-demand diagnostics.

Specification	ATT	Placebo SE	Normal p	Rank p (dir./bilat.)
Current covariates	-0.268	0.143	0.061	Not computed
Preferred: no covariates	-0.273	0.131	0.037	0.031 / 0.073
Primary share x 2008-2009	-0.285	0.129	0.027	0.031 / 0.073
Agriculture/mining x 2008-2009	-0.284	0.128	0.026	Not computed
Price exposure x 2008-2009	-0.277	0.130	0.034	Not computed
Prior China share x 2008-2009	-0.284	0.130	0.029	Not computed

Note:

Outcome is absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China; ATT is the estimated average causal effect on Brazil after 2009, so negative values mean convergence. SE: synthdid placebo SE with 5,000 replications. Window: 1997-2015 annual SDiD panel. All rows keep the binary 2009 China number-one treatment onset. Comparison rows use 5,000-replication placebo SEs with a common permutation seed; the preferred row reuses the pipeline standard error (20,000 replications). The preferred row uses no covariates; the current-covariates row is a comparison. Primary-goods measures use external goods exports only. The 2008-2009 interactions include the first treated year and are mechanism robustness checks, not preferred total-effect specifications. Rank inference was computed for the preferred specification and the primary-share x 2008-2009 interaction; 'Not computed' does not denote a failed test.

4.1 Issue-Area Evidence: Where Did Convergence Occur?

The aggregate ideal-point estimate raises a substantive question: in what kinds of votes did Brazil move closer to China? Resolution-level diagnostics suggest that the post-2009 convergence was selective rather than uniform. Figure 5 disaggregates the convergence rate by year and substantive issue family. In several issue areas Brazil and China already voted together at high rates before treatment, leaving little room for additional convergence. The more informative domain is human rights, where pre-treatment agreement was lower and where movement toward China carried greater reputational costs for Brazil, given the domestic and international implications of Brazil's human-rights foreign policy (Milani 2015).

In that domain, Brazil-China identical voting increased by 7.5 percentage points after 2009. This pattern is consistent with the proposed mechanism because it locates the clearest movement in a visible multilateral arena where Brazil had previously maintained more distance. It does not, however, show that the trade-rank cue itself caused the selective shift or that policymakers relied on it in particular decisions.

The strongest support comes from human-rights resolutions in which China and the United States diverged, where Brazil moves closer to China relative to comparable donor countries after 2009.

This descriptive increase does not by itself establish China-specific alignment, because annual issue-area shares can reflect agenda composition and do not compare Brazil with donor countries. To address such issues, I ran regressions with country and resolution fixed effects, restricted to human-rights votes where China and the United States cast different votes.

The results show that Brazil moves closer to China after 2009 relative to the donor pool. The Brazil-by-post-2009 coefficient is -0.357 for distance to China minus distance to the United States (model-based SE = 0.021), and -0.414 when the sample is restricted to strong yes/no China-US disagreements (model-based SE = 0.023). The corresponding non-human-rights estimate is smaller (-0.131, model-based SE = 0.012). These are not



Figure 5: Brazil-China identical UNGA votes by issue area, 2005-2012. Points report annual shares; the vertical line marks 2009. The clearest pattern expected by the mechanism is selective convergence in human rights. Note: Percentage of roll-call resolutions with identical Brazil-China votes. Window: 2005-2012 annual series; multi-coded resolutions enter each issue family.

causal estimates, given the usual selection and omitted-variable concerns.

However, restricting attention to a single issue domain opens a design that ideal points computed over all votes cannot support: a triple difference. Ideal points compress every resolution in a session into one score, leaving no contrast between issue domains to exploit, whereas vote-level data preserve it. Thus, I can not only compare the difference between Brazil and other untreated countries before and after (traditional DiD), but also include a third difference: across domains within the same country and year, comparing Brazil with the donor pool, before and after 2009, in human-rights votes relative to every other vote. Identification here asks for more than parallel trends between treated and control units: whatever bias a non-parallel trend introduces must be the same in the two issue domains, so that it cancels in the third difference (Olden and Møen 2022). Appendix Figure 9 displays the pre- and post-2009 Brazil-donor gaps in both domains; this descriptive comparison does not establish the identifying restriction.

Let B_i identify Brazil, P_r indicate 2009–2012, and H_r identify a human-rights resolution. The vote-level specification is

$$Y_{ir} = \alpha_i + \lambda_r + \beta(B_i P_r) + \gamma(B_i H_r) + \delta(B_i P_r H_r) + \varepsilon_{ir}.$$

Country and resolution fixed effects absorb the remaining lower-order terms. The Brazil-by-domain interaction allows Brazil's pre-existing gap relative to donors to differ between human-rights and other resolutions. The coefficient δ measures the additional post-2009 human-rights shift. The sample contains 55,190 observed votes by 95 countries on 612 China-US divergent resolutions in 2005–2012. Any human-rights tag places a resolution in the human-rights group; all remaining resolutions form the non-human-rights group. Each observed country-resolution vote receives equal weight. The specification does not absorb a separate domain intercept for each donor country; interpretation also requires changes in donor vote availability not to generate the differential shift across domains.

The DDD estimate is -0.222 for distance to China minus distance to the United States (country-clustered model-based SE = 0.014). Its negative sign indicates a larger shift to-

ward China in human-rights votes. With Brazil as the single treated country, I also reassign the treated-country role to each country, rebuilding all three interactions and retaining the same sample and fixed effects. In this DDD-specific distribution, Brazil ranks 9 of 95 in the predicted direction (inclusive directional tail share = 0.095; strict donor-only share = 0.085; two-sided absolute share = 0.126). These are descriptive reassignment benchmarks; interpreting them as randomization inference requires exchangeability of country assignment.

The separate human-rights-only DiD estimate of -0.357 ranks 6 of 95 in its own country-placebo distribution (inclusive directional share = 0.063; strict donor-only share = 0.053). This benchmark evaluates the within-domain post-2009 contrast, whereas the DDD benchmark evaluates the additional shift across domains.

Table 6: Brazil-China identical UNGA votes by issue area, before and after 2009.

Issue area	Pre-2009 identical vote share	Post-2009 identical vote share	Change	Interpretation
Human rights	69.6	77.1	7.5	Politically costly convergence; mechanism-informative
Arms/disarmament/nuclear	83.0	84.3	1.2	Diagnostic evidence
Economic development	92.9	90.0	-2.9	Diagnostic evidence
Decolonization	94.1	98.1	4.0	Diagnostic evidence
Palestine/Middle East	100.0	100.0	0.0	High baseline agreement; limited room to move
Other / uncoded	73.4	83.1	9.7	Heterogeneous residual category

Note:

Percentage of roll-call resolutions with identical Brazil-China votes. Window: 2005-2008 versus 2009-2012; multi-coded resolutions enter each issue family. Rows are label-specific diagnostics, not a mutually exclusive decomposition of the aggregate convergence pattern.

The DDD estimate indicates a larger human-rights shift than the analogous non-human-rights shift. Its country-placebo distribution provides moderate evidence for that additional shift and counsels against language implying that Brazil is unique. The Brazil evidence therefore supports a cautious claim of selective UNGA adjustment toward China in politically visible domains, rather than a claim that Table 6 alone proves selective convergence.

5 Brazilian Media Saliency

To assess whether trade-topic saliency increased around the rank reversal, I examine coverage of China in *Folha de S.Paulo*, Brazil's widest-circulation newspaper (*Folha de S.Paulo* 2016), from 2000 to 2014. Saliency matters because the rank-threshold argument requires the top-rank cue to become politically usable. A change in export hierarchy can shape elite and public attention when it appears in a prominent national newspaper as a simple signal of China's commercial importance, consistent with work on media, agenda setting, and foreign policy (Soroka 2003; Baum and Potter 2008; Walgrave and Van Aelst 2006).

Headlines are the appropriate unit for this trade-topic diagnostic because they are tractable in large archives and operate as attention-directing cues (Zhang and Yu 2024). The relevant question is whether *Folha* increasingly foregrounded China as a trade relationship after the rank reversal. Headlines are the most visible textual cue in the archive and the part of coverage most likely to be scanned by broad audiences. Full article texts would be useful for a different exercise – for example, measuring tone or detailed argumentation – but the saliency claim here is about which China-related themes were made visible at the headline level. This diagnostic does not measure the frequency of explicit rank labels.

I therefore classify China-related headlines into substantive categories and then collapse them into four analytically relevant groups: China-Brazil trade, China's domestic economy, diplomacy and bilateral relations, and non-economic coverage. The classification uses a fixed label set with examples, and the appendix reports the exact prompt and validation procedure. Figure 6 compares 2000–2008 with 2009–2014 and shows a substantial increase in China-Brazil trade coverage, from an average of 47 to 73 headlines per year (about 55 percent), alongside a larger increase in coverage of the Chinese economy, from 147 to 311 headlines per year (about 111 percent). Together, these patterns are consistent with increased media attention to China's economic importance for Brazil, as the proposed mechanism predicts. The figure supports the trade-topic-saliency step, but it does not by itself establish the public availability of an explicit rank cue. The separate contemporary sources below provide evidence about rank language.

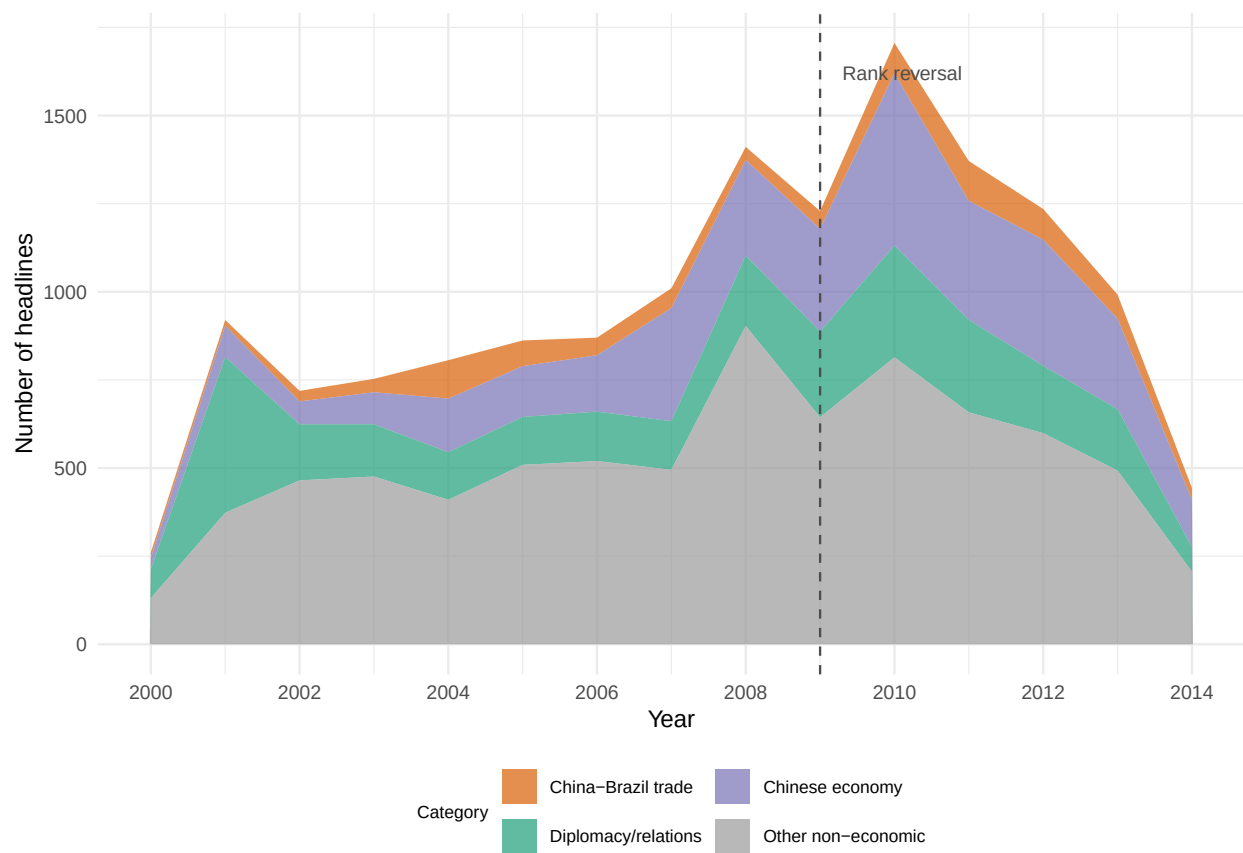


Figure 6: Brazilian media salience: disaggregated China headlines in Folha de S.Paulo by category. From 2000–2008 to 2009–2014, China-Brazil trade coverage increases substantially and coverage of the Chinese economy increases even more; together, the changes are consistent with heightened attention to China’s economic importance for Brazil. Note: Headlines per category per year. Window: 2000-2014 annual series.

The evidence distinguishes public availability from official uptake. The status cue became publicly available during the 2009 treatment year, before the full-year trade table was finalized. In early May, contemporary coverage of January–April trade statistics reported a historic shift in Brazil’s trade hierarchy: China had become Brazil’s largest trading partner and had purchased US\$5.627 billion in Brazilian exports, compared with US\$4.925 billion purchased by the United States (Agência Brasil 2009). This real-time visibility matters for the mechanism. The empirical design codes treatment annually because the outcome and comparative trade data are annual, but officials, journalists, and firms encountered the rank cue through contemporaneous monthly and year-to-date statistics. Lula’s May 2009 Beijing visit then provides evidence of official uptake during the treatment year: the new rank was already available as a public category around which diplomatic priorities could be narrated. Brazilian officials subsequently invoked China’s new position in Brazil’s trade hierarchy when explaining diplomatic prioritization, bilateral upgrading, and institutional follow-up.

In a written interview on the eve of his May 2009 visit to Beijing, President Lula described China as Brazil’s leading trading partner and framed the trip as an effort to consolidate cooperation across commerce, technology, and global economic governance (Ministério das Relações Exteriores and Fundação Alexandre de Gusmão 2009, 323). In Beijing three days later, Lula repeated the rank claim in speeches organized around the Brazil-China Strategic Partnership, trade diversification, investment, presidential diplomacy, and the preparation of the 2010–2014 Joint Action Plan (Ministério das Relações Exteriores and Fundação Alexandre de Gusmão 2009, 115, 121–22). The cue then persisted in Itamaraty language. When announcing Hu Jintao’s 2010 state visit and the signature of the Joint Action Plan, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs again invoked China’s 2009 rise to the top of Brazil’s trade hierarchy (Ministério das Relações Exteriores and Fundação Alexandre de Gusmão 2010, 356). Dilma Rousseff and Hu Jintao’s 2011 joint communiqué likewise noted that China had become Brazil’s principal trading partner in 2009 and embedded that status in an agenda of intensified dialogue over trade, investment, diversification, and implementation of the Joint Action Plan (Ministério das Relações Exteriores and Fundação Alexandre de Gusmão 2011a, 160–61). Later that year, Foreign Minister Antonio Patriota

made the institutional link explicit: in discussing China, he announced a dedicated Itamaraty task force to monitor economic-commercial relations with Brazil's principal trading partner and to propose ways to move the relationship beyond complementarity, toward diversification and higher value-added trade (Ministério das Relações Exteriores and Fundação Alexandre de Gusmão 2011b, 47).

These statements show official uptake of the 2009 status cue. Their co-occurrence with diplomatic prioritization and institutional attention is consistent with justificatory use, but it does not demonstrate that the cue caused those initiatives or particular UNGA decisions. The evidence therefore supports the availability and uptake steps directly and treats justificatory use as an inference compatible with the public mechanism implied by the theory: once China was officially recognized as central in Brazil's economic hierarchy, selective diplomatic accommodation could be presented as pragmatic recognition of national economic interests rather than as ideological concession or opportunistic bandwagoning.

6 Cross-Country Evidence Beyond Brazil

The cross-country analysis serves two purposes. First, it examines whether durable top-rank goods-export entry is followed by movement toward China beyond the Brazilian case. Second, it is an additional robustness check against explanations tied specifically to Brazil's 2009 calendar year, such as the global financial crisis, the BRICS/G20 moment, or the commodity cycle. If durable top-rank trade status matters, countries where China enters and holds the largest goods-export destination position should move closer to China in UNGA ideal-point space when aligned by their own treatment entry.

The two designs examine related but distinct implications of the argument. Brazil is the high-salience case: China displaced the United States, the hegemonic benchmark, and public availability and official uptake can be observed directly in media and official discourse. The cross-country panel evaluates whether entry into the number-one goods-export destination position is associated with the predicted directional pattern. Because public salience is not measured directly outside Brazil, the panel does not by itself validate

the goods-export rank as a proxy for public status change or extend the public mechanism to the larger sample.

I therefore estimate the same treatment logic in a goods-only status-current panel: treated country-years are those where China is rank 1 among goods-export destinations and the China-top period lasts at least five observed years. Never-China-top countries remain controls. Short China-top episodes and post-exit off-status years for treated countries are removed from the main risk set. This analysis evaluates whether the rank-threshold pattern is compatible with evidence beyond the theory-generating case while matching the durable treatment observed in Brazil. The corresponding estimand is the ATT on absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China for country-years in qualifying China-top periods.

The pooled cross-country ATT averages effects over all 440 country-years in which treatment is active. Under *fect*'s event-time convention, $h = 0$ denotes the last observed untreated year before entry and $h = +1$ the first treated year; $h = 0$ therefore serves only as a pre-entry diagnostic and is not included in the pooled ATT, which covers $h = +1$ through $h = +20$.

The preferred cross-country specification is the no-covariate IFE model on the goods-only restricted risk set. Table 7 reports it together with the clean single-entry robustness sample. The estimate is -0.101 ideal-point units (bootstrap SE = 0.039, 95 percent CI [-0.177, -0.024], $p = 0.010$). It corresponds to about 14.0 percent of the pre-treatment mean distance to China, or 0.124 standard deviations of the outcome. The estimate is in the theoretically expected negative direction and statistically distinguishable from zero at the 5 percent level. The clean single-entry robustness estimate is -0.122 ($p = 0.003$). Appendix Tables 17 and 19 report duration-threshold robustness and sample-coding audits.

Table 7: Cross-country IFE estimates for durable China top goods-export destination status.

Model	Estimator	ATT	SE	95% CI	p-value	Units (T/C)	Treated periods	Panel window	r*
Status-current, restricted risk set	IFE	-0.101	0.039	[-0.177, -0.024]	0.010	35/126	440	1990–2022	2
Clean single-entry robustness	IFE	-0.122	0.041	[-0.202, -0.042]	0.003	25/126	329	1990–2022	2

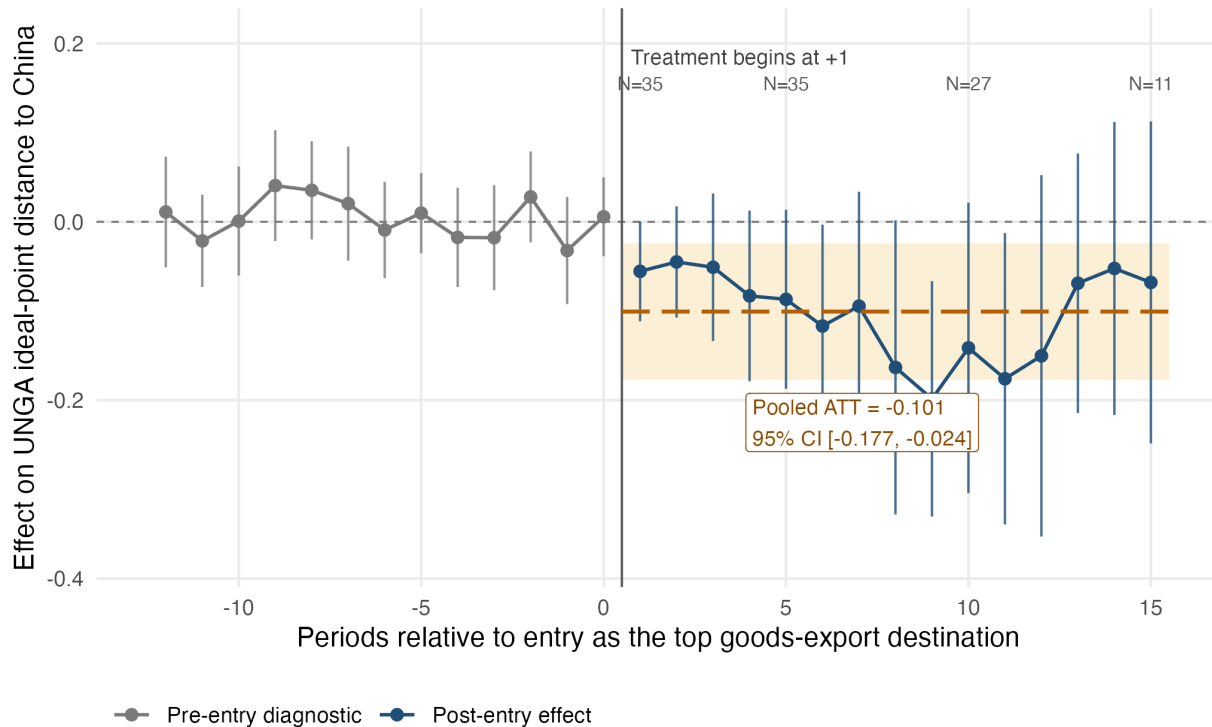
Note:

ATT in absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China; lower values indicate convergence toward China. SE: bootstrap with 10,000 replications. Window: 1990–2022 goods-only cross-country panel. Goods-only ranks are computed from ITPD-E Agriculture, Mining and Energy, and Manufacturing sectors; Services are excluded before ranks are constructed. Units (T/C) = treated/control units. For IFE rows, r* is the number of latent factors selected by cross-validation over $r = 0:3$. The restricted risk-set row is the main cross-country estimate. The clean single-entry row excludes treated countries with multiple China-top periods.

Figure 7 separates the event-time estimates from the pooled post-entry ATT for the main goods-only restricted-risk-set IFE specification. The pre-entry estimates shown in gray are centered near zero. 19 of the 20 post-entry point estimates are negative, with the largest reductions appearing approximately six to twelve years after entry, but most horizon-specific 95 percent intervals cross zero because each estimate uses only the countries observed at that horizon. The labels above selected horizons show how this support declines over time. The orange dashed line and band report the pooled ATT (-0.101, 95 percent CI [-0.177, -0.024]) across 440 treated country-years. This is a treated-period-weighted average, not a cumulative effect, which explains how the aggregate estimate can be distinguishable from zero even when most pointwise intervals are not.

Dynamic effects and the pooled post-entry ATT

Durable China top-export status; restricted-risk-set IFE specification



Points and vertical bars: event-time estimates and pointwise 95% bootstrap CIs.
Orange band and dashed line: pooled ATT and its 95% CI over all 440 treated country-years ($h=+1$ to $+20$).
This is a pooled average, not a cumulative sum. Display: $h=-12$ to $+15$.
N labels show contributing treated countries at selected post-entry horizons.

Figure 7: Dynamic effects and pooled post-entry ATT from the main goods-only cross-country IFE model. Gray points and vertical bars show pre-entry diagnostics; blue points and vertical bars show post-entry event-time estimates. Vertical bars are pointwise 95 percent bootstrap confidence intervals. The orange dashed line and band show the pooled ATT and its 95 percent bootstrap confidence interval across 440 treated country-years from $h = +1$ to $h = +20$; this is a treated-period-weighted average, not a cumulative sum. The display is limited to $h = -12$ through $h = +15$, and N labels give the number of contributing treated countries at selected post-entry horizons. Negative estimates indicate reduced UNGA distance to China after entry into durable status as the top goods-export destination. Note: Effect on absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China. SE: bootstrap confidence intervals. Window: 1990–2022 goods-only panel.

7 Conclusion

The evidence is consistent with a rank-threshold account of UNGA voting convergence toward China. In Brazil, China's 2009 move into the top export-destination position coincided with a publicly visible status cue. In the preferred SDiD specification, the estimated reduced-form effect of entry into this trade-rank condition is a reduction of 0.273 ideal-point units in Brazil's distance to China relative to its synthetic counterfactual; the design does not isolate the cue from other processes coincident with entry. Conventional inference and the theory-aligned directional placebo comparison support a negative effect, while the conservative two-sided placebo comparison is less decisive. The issue-area and vote-level evidence suggest that this convergence was selective rather than mechanical: the strongest additional support comes from human-rights resolutions where China and the United States diverged, and the human-rights shift is larger than the analogous non-human-rights shift. Figure 6 documents trade-topic salience, contemporary sources document the public availability of explicit rank language, and official statements document uptake. Their use as a justification for diplomatic adjustment remains an inference compatible with the evidence rather than a demonstrated causal link. Cross-country estimates from the goods-only IFE model show a compatible directional pattern associated with entry beyond Brazil, but public salience is measured directly only in the Brazilian case. The panel therefore extends the goods-only rank pattern, not the public mechanism itself.

The paper therefore shifts attention from trade volume alone to the possible political meaning of trade hierarchies. Continuous exposure matters, but categorical milestones – becoming first, displacing a hegemonic benchmark, and making an economic relationship publicly legible – may also create opportunities for selective diplomatic adjustment even when the underlying commercial relationship has been growing for years. The empirical results are consistent with this account while leaving the cue's isolated contribution unresolved.

For US-China competition, the Brazilian pattern directs attention to accommodation in specific arenas of multilateral disagreement. The clearest movement toward China occurred in human-rights votes on which the two powers diverged. The findings are consistent with

the possibility that publicly recognized changes in trade hierarchies create opportunities for such adjustments. This mechanism offers a possible link between China's commercial rise and changes in diplomatic support within the US-led international order.

Future research can extend the design in three directions. First, cross-country media data would allow the salience step to be tested beyond Brazil. Second, qualitative work on policymakers and business actors could identify how the rank cue entered diplomatic deliberation. Third, similar rank-threshold designs could be applied to investment, aid, lending, or other economic ties where categorical milestones may become politically usable.

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8 Appendix

The appendix reports the supporting diagnostics referenced in the main text: outcome and pre-trend series, resolution-level vote diagnostics, SDiD weights and donor-pool checks, the cross-country duration and sample audits, the ChatGPT classification and its validation, and the UNGA-DM measurement robustness.

8.1 Brazil and China Ideal-Point Series

Figure 8 plots the separate UNGA ideal-point series for Brazil and China. This diagnostic clarifies the interpretation of the absolute-distance outcome used in the main SDiD design: China remains comparatively stable, while Brazil accounts for most of the movement in the Brazil-China distance.

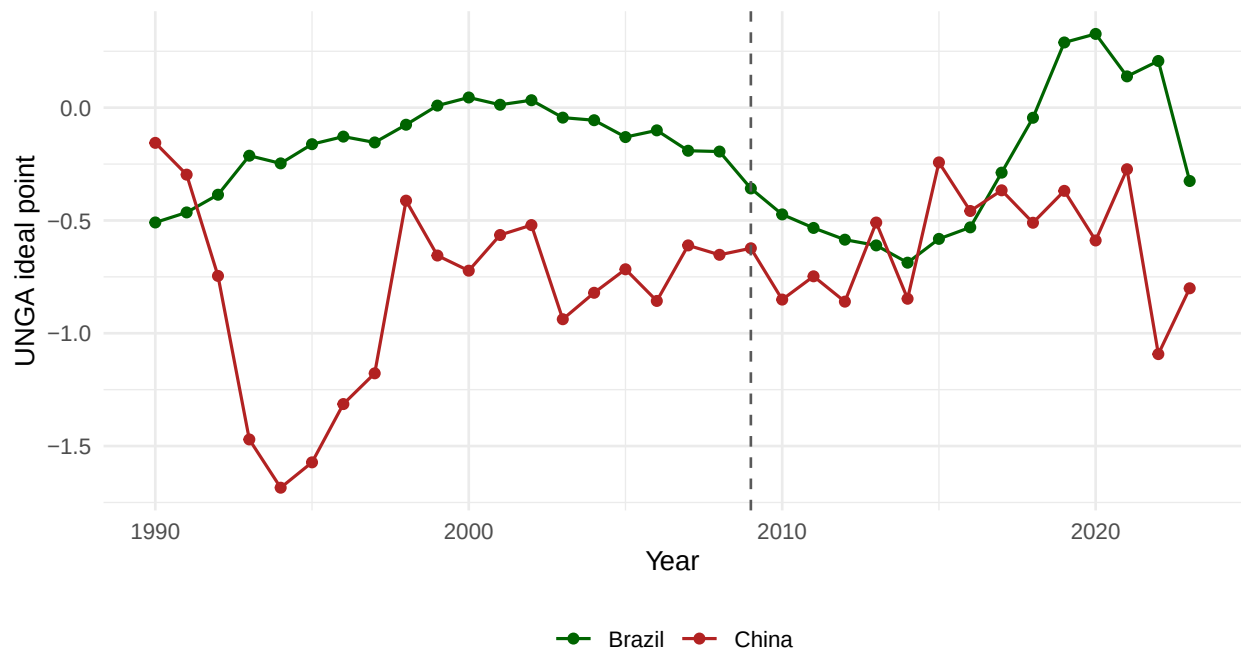


Figure 8: Brazil and China UNGA ideal-point series. The dashed line marks 2009. The figure separates the two series behind the absolute-distance outcome used in the main SDiD analysis. Note: UNGA ideal-point score (Bailey et al. scale). Window: 1990-2022 annual series.

8.2 Triple-Difference Pre-Trends

Figure 9 reports the input to the identification assumption behind the triple difference. Each series is Brazil's average distance to China minus its distance to the United States, net of the donor-pool average in the same year, computed separately for human-rights votes and for every other vote where China and the United States voted differently. What the triple difference requires is that these two series move together before treatment, so that any common drift cancels when one domain is differenced against the other.

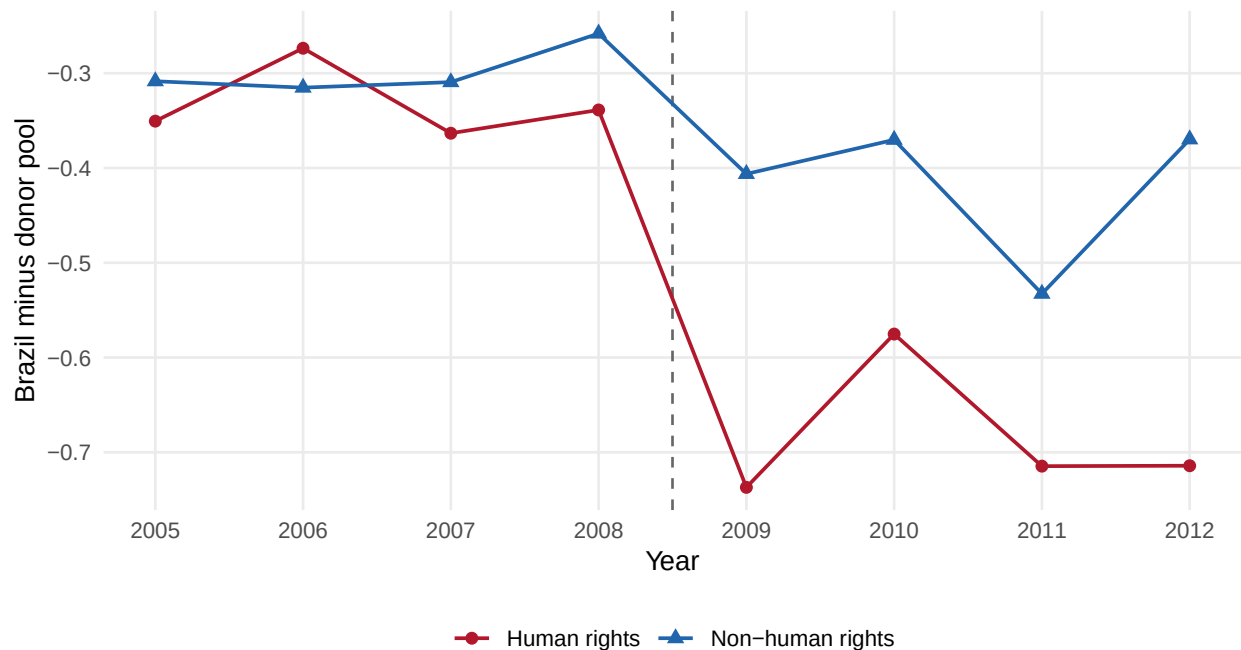


Figure 9: Brazil's distance from the donor pool in China-US divergent votes, by issue domain. Each point is Brazil's mean vote-level distance to China minus its distance to the United States, minus the donor-pool mean in the same year; more negative values mean Brazil sits closer to China than the donors do. The dashed line marks 2009. The two domains track each other before 2009 and separate afterward, which is the pattern the triple difference assumes and then estimates. Note: Vote-level distance to China minus distance to the United States, relative to the donor-pool mean. Window: 2005-2012 roll-call votes where China and the United States voted differently.

8.3 Resolution-Level UNGA Vote Diagnostics

To make the Brazil-China movement in UNGA ideal points more concrete, Table 8 reports the annual share of resolutions in which Brazil and China cast identical votes from 2005

to 2012. The diagnostic uses roll-call votes from `unvotes` 0.3.0, based on Erik Voeten's UNGA voting data, and excludes missing or absent votes by either Brazil or China.

Table 8: Brazil-China identical UNGA votes by year, 2005-2012.

Year	Resolutions	Identical votes	Identical votes (%)	Mean similarity score
2005	97	80	82.5	0.892
2006	108	88	81.5	0.884
2007	93	78	83.9	0.903
2008	96	73	76.0	0.859
2009	83	72	86.7	0.934
2010	85	74	87.1	0.906
2011	96	83	86.5	0.927
2012	90	71	78.9	0.872

Note:

Roll-call resolutions with valid Brazil and China votes; similarity score ranges from 0 to 1. Window: 2005-2012 annual series.

8.4 SDiD

8.4.1 Comparison of DiD, SCM, and SDiD Estimating Equations

To gain intuition for the SDiD estimator, it is useful to compare it with standard DiD and SCM. A DiD model estimates:

$$(\hat{\tau}_{ATT}^{DiD}, \hat{\mu}, \hat{\alpha}, \hat{\beta}) = \arg \min_{\tau_{ATT}, \mu, \alpha, \beta} \sum_{i=1}^N \sum_{t=1}^T (Y_{it} - \mu - \alpha_i - \beta_t - D_{it} \tau_{ATT})^2$$

While SDiD assigns larger weights to control units more similar to the treated unit and to time periods more comparable to the pre-treatment period, classic DiD does not use any weights at all.

The SCM model can be written as follows:

$$(\hat{\tau}_{ATT}^{SCM}, \hat{\mu}, \hat{\beta}) = \arg \min_{\tau_{ATT}, \mu, \beta} \sum_{i=1}^N \sum_{t=1}^T \hat{w}_i^{SCM} (Y_{it} - \mu - \beta_t - D_{it} \tau_{ATT})^2$$

Here $\hat{w}_i^{SCM}$ is the donor-unit weight assigned to unit i . SCM uses these donor weights to match the treated unit's pre-treatment outcome path, and effects are then read from post-treatment treated-minus-synthetic gaps. SCM can approximate stable unit differences through donor weights when the treated unit lies in the donor convex hull, but it does not add unit fixed effects or time weights. SDiD combines unit weights (like SCM) with unit fixed effects (like DiD) and time weights (unique to SDiD), addressing the limitations of both. The basic SDiD estimating equation is:

$$(\hat{\tau}_{ATT}^{SDiD}, \hat{\mu}, \hat{\alpha}, \hat{\beta}) = \arg \min_{\tau_{ATT}, \mu, \beta, \alpha} \sum_{i=1}^N \sum_{t=1}^T \hat{w}_i^{SDiD} \hat{\lambda}_t^{SDiD} (Y_{it} - \mu - \alpha_i - \beta_t - D_{it} \tau_{ATT})^2$$

Note that SDiD retains unit fixed effects α_i (like DiD) while also assigning unit weights $\hat{w}_i^{SDiD}$ (like SCM) and time weights $\hat{\lambda}_t^{SDiD}$ (unique to SDiD).

8.4.2 SDiD Weights and Donor Pool

Tables 9–16 report the Brazil SDiD diagnostic package behind the compact summary in Table 2. I report the complete donor-weight vector rather than only the largest donors, all pre-treatment time weights, fit and balance diagnostics, rank-based placebo inference, donor-influence checks, window sensitivity, and donor exposure to China's export expansion.

Table 9: Complete SDiD donor-unit weights for the Brazil synthetic counterfactual.

Rank	ISO3	Donor	Weight	Cumulative weight
1	GEO	Georgia	0.0313	0.0313
2	SGP	Singapore	0.0295	0.0608
3	TCD	Chad	0.0282	0.0890
4	GTM	Guatemala	0.0274	0.1164
5	PRY	Paraguay	0.0272	0.1436

6	BOL	Bolivia	0.0226	0.1662
7	ALB	Albania	0.0221	0.1883
8	COL	Colombia	0.0221	0.2103
9	DOM	Dominican Republic	0.0218	0.2322
10	IND	India	0.0213	0.2534
11	AZE	Azerbaijan	0.0210	0.2744
12	TUR	Turkey	0.0208	0.2953
13	DEU	Germany	0.0208	0.3160
14	MWI	Malawi	0.0182	0.3342
15	CRI	Costa Rica	0.0180	0.3522
16	FJI	Fiji	0.0176	0.3698
17	CYP	Cyprus	0.0168	0.3866
18	ARG	Argentina	0.0164	0.4031
19	PNG	Papua New Guinea	0.0164	0.4194
20	ISL	Iceland	0.0162	0.4357
21	HTI	Haiti	0.0158	0.4514
22	HUN	Hungary	0.0156	0.4670
23	BRB	Barbados	0.0155	0.4825
24	KEN	Kenya	0.0153	0.4978
25	NOR	Norway	0.0151	0.5129
26	SUR	Suriname	0.0150	0.5279
27	TTO	Trinidad & Tobago	0.0146	0.5424
28	DNK	Denmark	0.0141	0.5566
29	LTU	Lithuania	0.0137	0.5703
30	NIC	Nicaragua	0.0137	0.5840
31	HRV	Croatia	0.0137	0.5977
32	POL	Poland	0.0136	0.6113
33	SLV	El Salvador	0.0133	0.6246
34	TUN	Tunisia	0.0132	0.6379
35	EST	Estonia	0.0132	0.6511
36	PAK	Pakistan	0.0129	0.6640
37	JAM	Jamaica	0.0126	0.6765
38	MDV	Maldives	0.0121	0.6886
39	TGO	Togo	0.0118	0.7004
40	LVA	Latvia	0.0114	0.7118
41	ESP	Spain	0.0111	0.7229
42	LBN	Lebanon	0.0109	0.7338
43	SVN	Slovenia	0.0108	0.7446
44	MUS	Mauritius	0.0108	0.7554
45	DZA	Algeria	0.0108	0.7662
46	ROU	Romania	0.0105	0.7767
47	BGR	Bulgaria	0.0105	0.7872
48	GUY	Guyana	0.0103	0.7975
49	CZE	Czechia	0.0101	0.8076

50	AUT	Austria	0.0101	0.8177
51	JOR	Jordan	0.0098	0.8275
52	QAT	Qatar	0.0097	0.8372
53	SWE	Sweden	0.0093	0.8465
54	NAM	Namibia	0.0092	0.8557
55	PAN	Panama	0.0091	0.8648
56	FIN	Finland	0.0089	0.8737
57	NLD	Netherlands	0.0089	0.8826
58	COM	Comoros	0.0089	0.8915
59	SEN	Senegal	0.0088	0.9003
60	ISR	Israel	0.0085	0.9088
61	GRC	Greece	0.0085	0.9173
62	UGA	Uganda	0.0081	0.9254
63	PRT	Portugal	0.0081	0.9335
64	SVK	Slovakia	0.0078	0.9413
65	MDA	Moldova	0.0077	0.9490
66	ITA	Italy	0.0077	0.9567
67	MAR	Morocco	0.0071	0.9638
68	BTN	Bhutan	0.0062	0.9700
69	GBR	United Kingdom	0.0061	0.9760
70	USA	United States	0.0045	0.9806
71	CAN	Canada	0.0040	0.9845
72	LKA	Sri Lanka	0.0040	0.9885
73	BWA	Botswana	0.0036	0.9921
74	IRL	Ireland	0.0032	0.9952
75	LBY	Libya	0.0021	0.9973
76	UKR	Ukraine	0.0009	0.9983
77	FRA	France	0.0009	0.9992
78	ARE	United Arab Emirates	0.0004	0.9996
79	BGD	Bangladesh	0.0004	0.9999
80	EGY	Egypt	0.0000	1.0000
81	MEX	Mexico	0.0000	1.0000
82	BHR	Bahrain	0.0000	1.0000
83	BLR	Belarus	0.0000	1.0000
84	CIV	Côte d'Ivoire	0.0000	1.0000
85	CPV	Cape Verde	0.0000	1.0000
86	ECU	Ecuador	0.0000	1.0000
87	GAB	Gabon	0.0000	1.0000
88	GHA	Ghana	0.0000	1.0000
89	GIN	Guinea	0.0000	1.0000
90	KWT	Kuwait	0.0000	1.0000
91	MDG	Madagascar	0.0000	1.0000
92	NGA	Nigeria	0.0000	1.0000
93	RWA	Rwanda	0.0000	1.0000

94	SWZ	Eswatini	0.0000	1.0000
95	VEN	Venezuela	0.0000	1.0000

Note:

Weights sum to one over the donor pool; Brazil is excluded from the donor pool.

Table 10: SDiD pre-treatment time weights for the preferred Brazil specification.

Year	Time weight	Weight rank	High weight
1997	0.0000	8	No
1998	0.0248	6	No
1999	0.0979	4	No
2000	0.0000	8	No
2001	0.0000	8	No
2002	0.0000	8	No
2003	0.0000	8	No
2004	0.0150	7	No
2005	0.0807	5	No
2006	0.1282	3	Yes
2007	0.3020	2	Yes
2008	0.3515	1	Yes

Note:

The weights are assigned over the 1997-2008 pre-treatment period.

Table 11: Intercept-adjusted pre-treatment fit summary for the preferred Brazil SDiD specification.

Specification	ATT	Placebo SE	Adj. pre RMSPE	Adj. post RMSPE	Post/pre adj. RMSPE	Pre-treatment mean	% of pre-mean
Preferred: no covariates	-0.273	0.131	0.058	0.320	5.544	0.647	-42.2

Note:

ATT is the estimated average causal effect on Brazil after 2009, in absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China. RMSPE diagnostics subtract the mean pre-treatment gap between Brazil and its synthetic comparison before computing RMSPE, reflecting SDiD's allowance for stable level differences.

Table 12: Pre-treatment outcome balance and fixed values supplied in the preferred SDiD audit.

Variable	Definition	Brazil pre-mean	Synthetic pre-mean	Difference	Std. difference
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abs_distance_china	1997-2008 mean	0.647	0.987	-0.340	-0.432
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Note:

The preferred specification uses no covariates; these variables are reported as descriptive pre-treatment comparisons only. Synthetic values use the SDiD unit weights and are not residualized synthdid balance statistics.

Table 13: Directional and bilateral placebo-in-space rank inference for the preferred Brazil SDiD estimate.

Comparison set	Directional rank	Directional p	Absolute rank	Bilateral p	Denominator	Note
All valid assignments	3/96	0.031	7/96	0.073	96	Primary rank comparison
Pre-fit RMSPE no larger than twice Brazil	2/70	0.029	4/70	0.057	70	Fit-filter sensitivity; not used to select the main p-value

Note:

The primary distribution includes Brazil and all valid placebo-in-space assignments. The directional rank tests the theory-aligned direction of convergence; the bilateral absolute rank is the conservative two-sided counterpart. Interpreting these ranks as p-values requires sufficiently comparable placebo assignments; the donor exposure audit and the pre-fit filter probe, but cannot guarantee, that condition. The fit-filter row was not used to choose the main result.

Table 14: Sensitivity to influential donors and high-weight donor blocks.

Specification	ATT	Adj. pre RMSPE	Post/pre adj. RMSPE	Removed donors	% change	Inference
Preferred: no covariates	-0.273	0.058	5.544	0	0.0	Main SE and rank reported separately
Drop Georgia (rank 1)	-0.270	0.060	5.318	1	1.1	Point estimate only
Drop Singapore (rank 2)	-0.275	0.060	5.427	1	-1.0	Point estimate only
Drop Chad (rank 3)	-0.272	0.060	5.339	1	0.3	Point estimate only
Drop Guatemala (rank 4)	-0.277	0.059	5.453	1	-1.6	Point estimate only
Drop Paraguay (rank 5)	-0.274	0.059	5.412	1	-0.3	Point estimate only
Drop Bolivia (rank 6)	-0.263	0.058	5.423	1	3.6	Point estimate only
Drop Albania (rank 7)	-0.274	0.058	5.537	1	-0.5	Point estimate only
Drop Colombia (rank 8)	-0.270	0.059	5.357	1	1.2	Point estimate only
Drop Dominican Republic (rank 9)	-0.276	0.058	5.592	1	-1.0	Point estimate only
Drop India (rank 10)	-0.273	0.059	5.496	1	-0.2	Point estimate only
Drop top 10 donors by weight	-0.268	0.074	4.395	10	1.6	Point estimate only

Note:

Placebo SEs are not recomputed for donor-deletion rows; those rows are point-estimate and intercept-adjusted fit diagnostics.

Table 15: Sensitivity to plausible time windows around the preferred 1997-2015 specification.

Window	ATT	Adj. pre RMSPE	Post/pre adj. RMSPE	% change	Inference
1997-2013	-0.294	0.056	5.610	-7.8	Point estimate only
1997-2014	-0.320	0.057	6.066	-17.5	Point estimate only
1997-2015 preferred	-0.273	0.058	5.544	0.0	20,000-placebo SE and rank reported in main results
1997-2016	-0.278	0.059	5.624	-1.8	Point estimate only
1998-2015	-0.256	0.039	8.151	6.2	Point estimate only
1999-2015	-0.267	0.027	11.976	1.9	Point estimate only
2000-2015	-0.265	0.028	11.343	2.9	Point estimate only

Note:

The preferred 1997-2015 row uses the placebo SE and rank inference reported in the main results. Other windows are point-estimate and intercept-adjusted fit diagnostics; their placebo distributions were not recomputed.

Table 16: High-weight donor exposure to China in exports of goods and services.

Rank	ISO3	Donor	Weight	China share pre	China share post	Best post rank	Flag
1	GEO	Georgia	0.031	0.006	0.013	14	No top-two China export-destination exposure
2	SGP	Singapore	0.029	0.072	0.112	1	China top export destination post-2009
3	TCD	Chad	0.028	0.038	0.061	2	China top-two export destination post-2009
4	GTM	Guatemala	0.027	0.003	0.007	11	No top-two China export-destination exposure
5	PRY	Paraguay	0.027	0.007	0.006	21	No top-two China export-destination exposure
6	BOL	Bolivia	0.023	0.009	0.033	4	No top-two China export-destination exposure
7	ALB	Albania	0.022	0.012	0.067	2	China top-two export destination post-2009
8	COL	Colombia	0.022	0.008	0.056	2	China top-two export destination post-2009
9	DOM	Dominican Republic	0.022	0.004	0.021	3	No top-two China export-destination exposure
10	IND	India	0.021	0.049	0.060	3	No top-two China export-destination exposure

Note:

High-weight donors are the ten donors with the largest SDiD unit weights. China shares and destination ranks in this table include goods and services. Pre and post refer to 1997–2008 and 2009–2015, respectively; shares are annual averages within each window. Best post rank is China's highest export-destination position attained during 2009–2015. Donor eligibility instead uses goods-only ranks: no donor had China as its largest goods-export destination during 1997–2015. Among these high-weight donors, 1 had China as the top export destination in goods and services during 2009–2015 and 4 were cases where China ranked in the top two, accounting for 10.2 percent of total SDiD weight.

Below I also present the ten largest donor weights used in the main model as a visual summary.

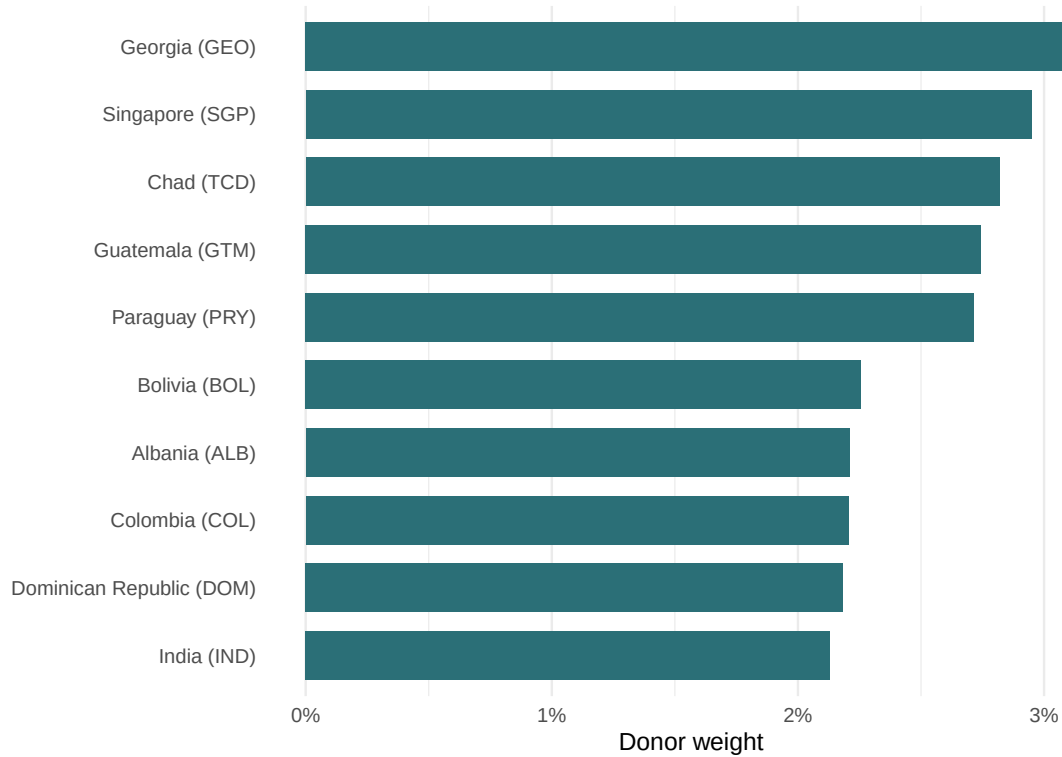


Figure 10: Ten largest donor weights contributing to the synthetic control in the Brazilian SDiD model. Note: Synthetic-control unit weights, normalized over the full donor pool rather than only over the displayed donors. Window: pre-treatment period ending in 2008.

I also fit a model for a donor pool of Latin American states (excluding Caribbean countries), which is substantively attractive because the donor countries are regionally closer to Brazil. This regional donor pool is a sensitivity check rather than the preferred specification: the main design seeks a pre-treatment synthetic counterfactual with adequate donor support and fit, while the Latin American pool is much smaller.

Latin America donors, estimated without covariates

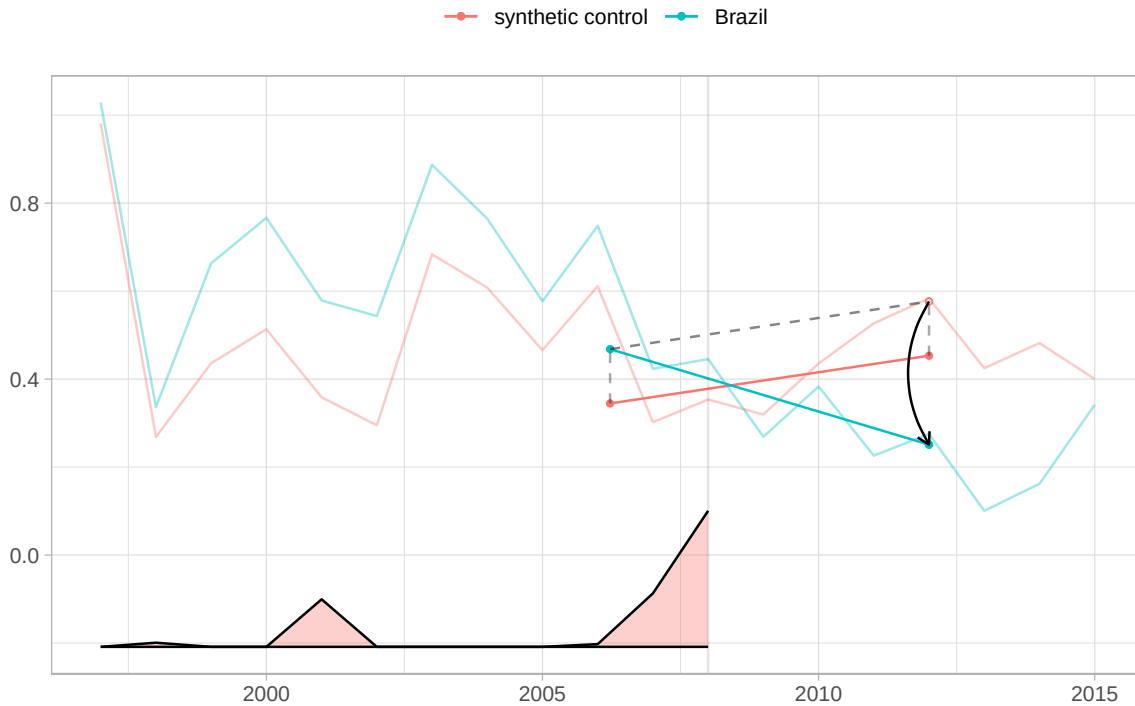


Figure 11: SDiD fit with a Latin American donor pool, estimated without covariates. Note: Absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China. SE: 0.207 (placebo, 20,000 replications). Window: 1997-2015 annual series.

Estimated without covariates, the Latin America donor-pool estimate has the same sign and a somewhat larger magnitude: -0.326 , compared with -0.273 in the global donor pool. The regional pool has only 19 donors and a slightly higher intercept-adjusted pre-treatment RMSPE (0.069 versus 0.058). Its placebo SE is 0.207, based on 20,000 replications, and the normal-approximation 95 percent interval $[-0.731, 0.080]$ includes zero. Because the directional placebo comparison is computed within this regional pool, which contains only 19 donor units, even Brazil being the 2nd most negative among all 20 assignments yields a p-value of only 0.100. In other words, the regional donor pool does not provide enough power to estimate the effect precisely. The point estimate is nevertheless consistent with the main result and, if anything, is somewhat larger in absolute value than the estimate from the larger global donor pool.

8.5 Cross-Country Robustness: Duration Thresholds

The main cross-country estimate uses a five-year durability threshold because the theory concerns status that persists long enough to become politically usable. Table 17 reports the same goods-only IFE design under three- and seven-year thresholds, along with the clean single-entry robustness sample. The estimates remain negative across the restricted-risk-set rows, though precision varies with treated-unit support.

Table 17: Duration-threshold robustness for goods-only China top export-destination status.

Minimum duration	Specification	ATT	SE	95% CI	p-value	Units (T/C)	Treated periods	r*
3	Status-current, restricted risk set	-0.113	0.041	[-0.193, -0.034]	0.005	39/126	477	2
3	Clean single-entry robustness	-0.121	0.041	[-0.202, -0.040]	0.003	26/126	332	2
5	Status-current, restricted risk set	-0.101	0.039	[-0.177, -0.024]	0.010	35/126	440	2
5	Clean single-entry robustness	-0.122	0.041	[-0.202, -0.042]	0.003	25/126	329	2
7	Status-current, restricted risk set	-0.094	0.040	[-0.173, -0.016]	0.019	31/126	411	2
7	Clean single-entry robustness	-0.122	0.042	[-0.205, -0.039]	0.004	23/126	318	2

Note:

ATT in absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China; lower values indicate convergence toward China. SE: bootstrap with 10,000 replications. Window: goods-only ITPD-E rank metric. The restricted-risk-set rows retain clean pre-entry non-China-top years and qualifying treated years. The clean single-entry rows additionally keep only treated countries with one observed qualifying China-top period.

8.6 Cross-Country Sample Audit: Goods-Only Treatment Coding

The revised rank metric excludes services before partner ranks are computed. Table 18 documents the ITPD-E broad-sector filter. Table 19 then summarizes how the five-year goods-only rule classifies countries in the UNGA/trade panel.

Table 18: ITPD-E sector filter used to construct the goods-only China top export-destination metric.

Broad sector	Raw rows	Positive-trade rows	Included in rank metric
Agriculture	7331458	2484549	Yes
Manufacturing	71208330	28203707	Yes
Mining and Energy	1205032	416413	Yes
Services	1002558	519520	No

Table 19: Country-level sample audit for the five-year goods-only China top export-destination rule.

Role	Countries
Excluded: no clean observed prior non-China-top year	1
Excluded: pre-2000 China-top entry	2
Excluded: short China-top periods	26
Never-China-top controls	128
Qualifying treated countries	35

Note:

The audit uses the goods-only rank metric and classifies countries before the estimator-specific screen for minimum untreated support. Country counts are therefore a coding audit, not a replacement for the treated/control counts in the estimation table.

8.7 Public Cue and Recoverability Audit

In order to assess how closely the empirical treatment used in the panel regression – China becoming a country’s largest destination for goods exports – maps onto the theorized treatment (a publicly salient change in status), I conducted a cross-country audit of news media and official sources. The audit examines whether explicit rank language can be recovered around the time of treatment entry and whether source coverage is sufficiently complete for non-recovery to count as informative silence. Table 20 therefore distinguishes among observed status cues concerning China, the recoverability of the displaced incumbent, and caveats about the underlying trade metric. Cases in which no status cue was recovered

are not automatically interpreted as showing that the cue was absent. Non-recovery may instead reflect limited access to contemporaneous records many years after the event, especially in countries where official speeches and news archives are less systematically preserved or digitized. Table 21 reports the Australian source in full.

Table 20: Recoverability and metric caveats in the former-incumbent salience audit.

Country	Entry year	China cue	Ex-#1 benchmark	Interpretation	Caveat
Solomon Islands	2003	unknown	unknown	Weak observation/recoverability problem	Additional local/official archive work required.
Philippines	2005	unknown	unknown	Weak observation/recoverability problem	Treatment-rank audit issue in contemporaneous sources.
Angola	2007	unknown	unknown	Weak observation/recoverability problem	Additional local/official archive work required.
Malaysia	2009	unknown	medium	Benchmark recoverable; follow up before recoding salience	Rank-definition and China/Hong Kong aggregation caveat.
Australia	2009	unknown	medium	Metric mismatch/status already salient	Australian Financial Review uses aggregate trade; not counted for export-destination uptake.
Sierra Leone	2012	unknown	unknown	Weak observation/recoverability problem	Local statistics conflict with Belgium-as-incumbent.
Myanmar (Burma)	2014	unknown	unknown	Weak observation/recoverability problem	Additional local/official archive work required.
Gabon	2017	unknown	unknown	Weak observation/recoverability problem	Additional local/official archive work required.
Kuwait	2018	unknown	unknown	Weak observation/recoverability problem	Additional local/official archive work required.

Note:

The table is built from the supplemental former-incumbent audit tables. Australia's entry year follows the current goods-only annual panel (2009); source publication dates retain their original values. The former-incumbent benchmark asks whether the export partner displaced by China was covered in recoverable local or official sources. It is a recoverability diagnostic, not a rule for coding China salience as absent.

Table 21: Australian Financial Review context source for Australia.

Source	Australian Financial Review
Date	2009-11-09
Metric	Australia's largest aggregate trading partner
Counted in export-destination benchmark	No
Raw file	data/raw/ex_top1_salience/AUS/2009/ australian_financial_review/ aus_afr_china_trading_partner_2009.html
Interpretation	DO_NOT_COUNT: broad trade-partner metric combines exports and imports, goods and services; not evidence of export-destination status. Retained as metric-mismatch and salience context.

Note:

The AFR item documents a broad aggregate-trading-partner cue. It documents broad-metric salience during the 2009 annual treatment window. The publication date does not establish that a strict goods-export cue preceded treatment.

8.8 ChatGPT Classification

Below is the coded instruction to the ChatGPT API to classify the subjects of the headlines.

```
system_block <- paste(
  paste0(
    'You are a Brazilian expert in International Relations and ',
    'the political'
  ),
  paste0(
    'economy of China-Brazil relations. Classify the subject ',
    'of EACH headline'
  ),
  paste0(
    'when I say EACH, I mean all of them, even if repetitive or ',
    'similar. Do classify all of them'
  ),
  'using one label from this list exactly as written:',
  '"diplomacy", "chinese economy", "china-brasil relations",',
  '"disaster and accidents", "chinese politics and policy",',
  '"sports, science, culture, other", "human rights",',
  '"china-brazil trade", "health".\n\n',
  # 13 static few-shot examples - leave them unchanged!
  'Examples:\n',
  paste0(
    '1. Presidente chinês visita o Brasil e participa de ',
    'reunião com FHC -> china-brasil relations\n'
  ),
  paste0(
    '2. Ministro chinês de Defesa faz visita oficial ao Brasil ',
    '-> china-brasil relations\n'
  ),
  paste0(
    '3. Para governo, novo câmbio chinês só beneficia Brasil no ',
    'médio prazo -> china-brazil trade\n'
  ),
  paste0(
    '4. China ultrapassa EUA como maior parceiro comercial do ',
    'Brasil -> china-brazil trade\n'
  ),
  paste0(
    '5. China vai controlar preços de alimentos e combustíveis ',
    '-> chinese economy\n'
  ),
  ,
```

```

paste0(
  '6. Vendas de automóveis na China desaceleram em junho -> ',
  'chinese economy\n'
),
paste0(
  '7. China quer devolução das relíquias Yin, patrimônio da ',
  'Unesco -> sports, science, culture, other\n'
),
paste0(
  '8. Dinossauro encontrado na China esclarece origem das ',
  'aves -> sports, science, culture, other\n'
),
paste0(
  '9. OMS confirma mais de 4.600 casos de gripe suína; China ',
  'registra 2º caso -> health\n'
),
paste0(
  '10. Marinha chinesa busca "cansar" barcos japoneses em ',
  'águas disputadas -> diplomacy\n'
),
paste0(
  '11. Acidente após casamento deixa 16 mortos na China -> ',
  'disaster and accidents\n'
),
paste0(
  '12. Jornal chinês sai das bancas por foto da praça ',
  'Tiananmen -> human rights\n'
),
paste0(
  '13. China é parceira estratégica contra crise econômica, ',
  'diz UE -> chinese economy'
),
paste0(
  'return as in the examples, a string with the headline and ',
  'the classification'
)
)

```

The classified headline file is treated as an archived derived dataset rather than regenerated during manuscript rendering. This choice reflects the practical behavior of LLM-based coding: early runs sometimes returned incomplete classifications, altered original headlines, or used slightly inconsistent labels, which made exact matching back to the archive

difficult. I therefore fixed the prompt, normalized labels, preserved the resulting classified file, and validated the coding below against an independently coded sample. The evidence in the main text is used as a headline-level salience diagnostic.

Below I reproduce the 14 archived headline examples and their ChatGPT classifications.

Examples of Classified Headlines

Archived sample: 14 headlines with ChatGPT-assigned topic

Headline	Classification	Date
Disputa com Brasil é 'conflito menor' para China, dizem analistas	china-brazil relations	2005-10-05
Lula vai se encontrar com presidente da China na segunda	china-brazil relations	2004-05-23
China lidera as aquisições de empresas brasileiras	china-brazil trade	2013-03-01
China aceita nova regra brasileira e suspende embargo à soja	china-brazil trade	2004-06-21
PIB da China dobra participação no total mundial em 5 anos	chinese economy	2011-03-25
BHP prevê produção recorde de minério de ferro e aposta na China	chinese economy	2012-01-18
China ameaça Google com "consequências" caso empresa largue autocensura	chinese politics and policy	2010-03-12
China anuncia fechamento de 700 websites	chinese politics and policy	2004-08-01
China não quer interferência dos EUA na questão do Tibete	diplomacy	2011-09-28
Chega a Taiwan primeiro voo direto da China em quase 60 anos	diplomacy	2008-07-04
Incêndio em prédio residencial deixa 12 mortos na China	disaster and accidents	2010-07-19
China detona barragens e prédios danificados; veja vídeo	disaster and accidents	2008-06-06
Uma em três chinesas da zona rural se mata por ano	health	2002-11-29
China suspende viagens ao Tibete para controlar Sars	health	2003-05-13

Figure 12: Fourteen archived examples of China-related Folha de S.Paulo headlines and ChatGPT classifications. Note: headline text and category labels. Window: sample drawn from the 2000-2014 corpus.

8.8.1 Validation of ChatGPT Classification

To assess the reliability of the automated classification, I independently coded a stratified random sample of 100 headlines (with a minimum of 5 per category). Table 22 reports the agreement rate between the ChatGPT labels and the manual coding.

Table 22: Validation of ChatGPT classification against manual coding (N = 100). Overall accuracy: 88.0 percent.

Category	N	Correct	Accuracy (%)
china-brazil trade	6	6	100.0
disaster and accidents	13	13	100.0
health	6	6	100.0
chinese economy	25	24	96.0
human rights	8	7	87.5
diplomacy	12	10	83.3
sports, science, culture, other	17	14	82.4
china-brazil relations	5	4	80.0
chinese politics and policy	8	4	50.0
Overall	100	88	88.0

Note:

headline-level counts and accuracy (percent) by category. Window: stratified validation sample from the 2000-2014 headline corpus.

The overall accuracy is 88.0 percent. The lowest agreement is in the “chinese politics and policy” category (50.0 percent), where several headlines were manually reclassified as “diplomacy.” The category most central to the mechanism, “china-brazil trade,” achieved 100.0 percent agreement. Related bilateral categories had lower but still usable agreement: 80.0 percent for “china-brazil relations” and 83.3 percent for “diplomacy.”

8.9 Cross-Country: Goods-Only Treated Countries

Table 23 describes the 35 treated countries in the main goods-only restricted-risk-set specification. For each country, the table reports the first qualifying China-top goods-export year and the number of treated and untreated country-years retained in the estimation panel.

Table 23: Treated countries in the main goods-only restricted-risk-set cross-country specification.

Country	ISO3c	Treatment year	Treated years	Pre/other untreated years	First panel year	Last panel year
Sudan	SDN	2000	6	10	1990	2005
Solomon Islands	SLB	2003	20	13	1990	2022
South Korea	KOR	2003	20	12	1991	2022
Cuba	CUB	2004	18	14	1990	2022
Oman	OMN	2004	19	13	1990	2022
Philippines	PHL	2005	18	15	1990	2022
Yemen	YEM	2005	11	13	1991	2015
Mauritania	MRT	2006	17	15	1990	2022
Angola	AGO	2007	16	17	1990	2022
Chile	CHL	2007	16	17	1990	2022
Iran	IRN	2007	13	17	1990	2019
Kazakhstan	KAZ	2007	16	15	1992	2022
Congo - Kinshasa	COD	2008	14	18	1990	2022
Japan	JPN	2008	15	18	1990	2022
North Korea	PRK	2008	12	13	1991	2019
Thailand	THA	2008	14	18	1990	2021
Australia	AUS	2009	14	19	1990	2022
Brazil	BRA	2009	14	19	1990	2022
Malaysia	MYS	2009	14	19	1990	2022
South Africa	ZAF	2009	14	15	1994	2022
Peru	PER	2010	13	20	1990	2022
Turkmenistan	TKM	2010	13	18	1992	2022
Congo - Brazzaville	COG	2011	12	18	1990	2022
Zimbabwe	ZWE	2011	7	21	1990	2017
Russia	RUS	2012	11	20	1992	2022
Sierra Leone	SLE	2012	11	22	1990	2022
New Zealand	NZL	2013	10	23	1990	2022
Saudi Arabia	SAU	2013	10	23	1990	2022
Uruguay	URY	2013	10	23	1990	2022
Eritrea	ERI	2014	9	21	1993	2022
Myanmar (Burma)	MMR	2014	9	24	1990	2022
Indonesia	IDN	2016	7	25	1990	2022
Equatorial Guinea	GNQ	2017	6	18	1995	2022
Gabon	GAB	2017	6	27	1990	2022
Kuwait	KWT	2018	5	28	1990	2022

Note:

Ranks are computed from goods exports only. The restricted risk set keeps clean pre-entry non-China-top years and qualifying treated years for treated countries. Treatment year is the first retained year of a qualifying China-top goods-export period.

8.10 Measurement Robustness: UNGA-DM Ideal Points

The main estimations in the paper used the classic ideal-point measurement by BSV (Bailey, Strezhnev, and Voeten 2017) as the response variable. However, according to Fjelstul, Hug, and Kilby (2026), the set of resolutions included in the BSV dataset is not complete. They provided a broader dataset, along with re-estimations of ideal points based on the new data. To assess whether the results of the paper change with this new measurement, I reran the main estimations with this new response variable. To make the comparison as close as possible, I held the treatment definition, donor and risk-set rules, covariate structure, and inference conventions fixed. The UNGA-DM series has a shorter time window, and the SDiD unit and time weights and the IFE factor count are re-estimated by their algorithms in response to the outcome series. These induced adjustments mean that the comparison evaluates the robustness of the analysis package to the alternative outcome; it is not a pure measurement-only perturbation of an otherwise identical fitted counterfactual. It is also important to note that 28 country-session rows had no ISO3c match and 0 SDiD rows had no outcome in the alternative measurement.

The two outcome measures preserve the negative direction of the Brazilian SDiD estimate, but they do not support a blanket claim of robustness across the Brazilian and cross-country designs. Table 24 shows the comparison. Under UNGA-DM, the point estimate is nominally higher than the original in absolute terms (-0.331 versus -0.273), with a lower p-value of 0.008. The directional rank is the same in both measurements (3/96 (0.031)). The bilateral rank improves from 7/96 (0.073) to 5/96 (0.052). It is noteworthy that the pre-treatment averages are different (0.647 against 0.837) in the original estimation. But the effect measured as a percentage of the pre-treatment average is similar: -42.2 and -39.5 percent. The Brazilian result therefore retains its direction and inferential support under the alternative measure, with a similar relative magnitude. The cross-country comparison below is more sensitive to the outcome source: its IFE estimate is materially smaller and less precise under UNGA-DM. The 2×2 comparison below holds the common window and country-year panel fixed while varying the outcome source and factor count, so the contribution of factor selection can be assessed separately from the outcome-source

difference.

Table 24: Brazil SDiD under two sources of UNGA ideal points. Both columns use the same panel, the same donor pool, and the same placebo standard error settings; the outcome series is the only input that differs, and the synthetic-control weights are re-estimated from it.

	Bailey, Strezhnev and Voeten	Fjelstul, Hug and Kilby
ATT	-0.273	-0.331
Placebo standard error	0.131	0.125
95 percent confidence interval	[-0.529, -0.017]	[-0.576, -0.085]
p (normal approximation, two-sided)	0.037	0.008
Directional placebo rank (p)	3/96 (0.031)	3/96 (0.031)
Two-sided absolute placebo rank (p)	7/96 (0.073)	5/96 (0.052)
Intercept-adjusted pre-treatment RMSPE	0.058	0.058
Brazil pre-treatment outcome mean	0.647	0.837
ATT as percent of pre-treatment mean	-42.2	-39.5

Note:

Estimates are the post-2009 gap in absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China, 1997-2015 annual panel, no covariates. Placebo SEs use 20,000 replications and seed 20260520 in both columns. Placebo-in-space ranks involve no random draws and are exactly reproducible.

Figure 13 reports the placebo-in-space distribution for the UNGA-DM SDiD fit. It is close to the distribution obtained under the original outcome. The directional placebo rank is unchanged under the alternative measure (3/96 (0.031) in both columns), while the bilateral absolute rank improves from 7/96 (0.073) to 5/96 (0.052). Table 24 reports this cross-measure comparison, and Table 25 reports the donor-exclusion checks under UNGA-DM.

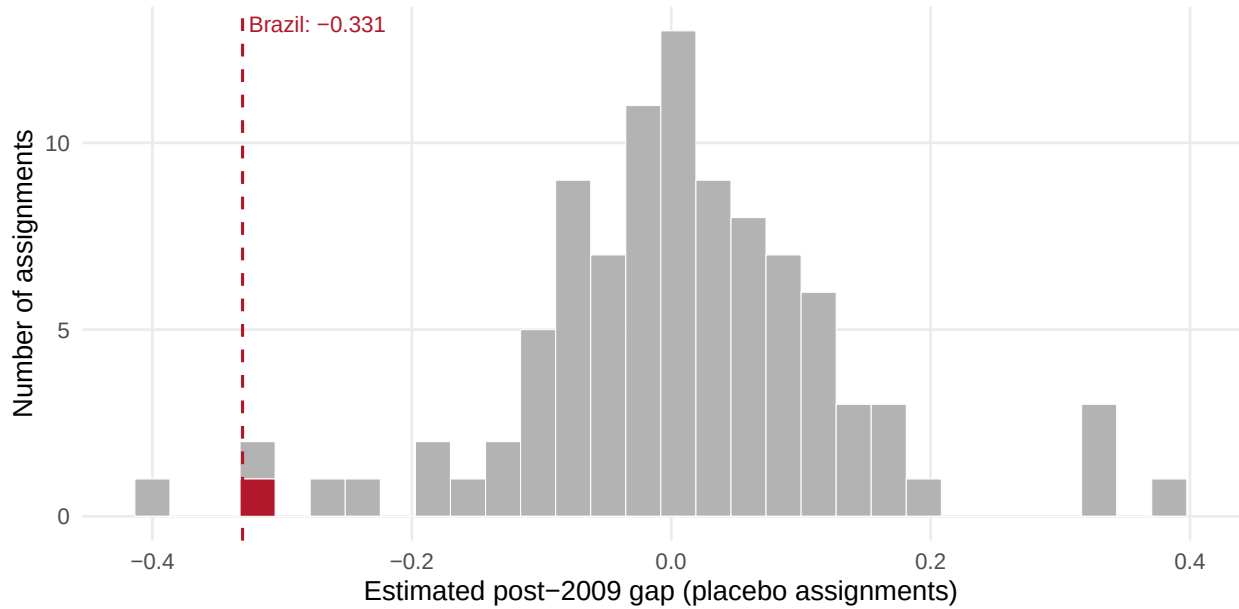


Figure 13: Placebo-in-space distribution under the UNGA-DM outcome, with Brazil marked. Brazil's estimate is the 3rd most negative of 96 assignments (directional $p = 0.031$); the two-sided absolute rank is 5/96 ($p = 0.052$). Negative values indicate convergence toward China. Note: Estimated post-2009 gap in absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China, UNGA-DM measure. Window: 1997-2015 annual SDiD panel.

Table 25: Placebo rank inference under the UNGA-DM outcome, by donor-exclusion criterion.

Comparison set	Excluded donors	Directional rank (p)	Two-sided rank (p)
All valid assignments	—	3/96 (0.031)	5/96 (0.052)
Exclude goods-only China-top donor assignments (harmonized: window criterion)	—	3/96 (0.031)	5/96 (0.052)
Exclude goods-only China-top donor assignments (legacy 5-year qualifying criterion; audit only)	GAB, KWT	3/94 (0.032)	5/94 (0.053)

Note:

The window criterion excludes donors observed as China-top in goods exports within 1997-2015, which is the criterion used elsewhere in the paper. The legacy criterion excludes countries that qualify under the five-year duration rule outside the analysis window, and is reported for audit only.

Donor weights are estimated separately for each fit, so they are not identical across out-

comes. Table 26 reports how much they change. Weight is spread among donors in a similar way in both fits: 0.044 under UNGA-DM and 0.031 under BSV. The correlation of the donor pool weights is moderate (0.462), but among the top ten donors, 6 are the same. The donor mix therefore shifts moderately across outcomes. For Brazil, the negative estimate and similar relative magnitude are preserved, but the two fits do not use identical counterfactual weights; this comparison does not establish stability of the cross-country result.

Table 26: Ten largest synthetic-control donor weights under the UNGA-DM fit, with the weight the same donor receives under the main outcome.

Donor	UNGA-DM weight	BSV weight
COL	0.044	0.022
IND	0.031	0.021
SEN	0.031	0.009
BRB	0.029	0.015
GTM	0.027	0.027
GHA	0.026	0.000
TTO	0.026	0.015
PRY	0.026	0.027
BOL	0.025	0.023
SGP	0.023	0.029

Note:

Weights are normalized over the full donor pool of 95 units rather than over the displayed donors. The ten donors shown carry 28.8 percent of total weight under the UNGA-DM fit. Across all donors, the correlation between the two weight vectors is 0.462, and 6 of the ten largest donors are shared by the two fits.

Regarding the panel regression, Table 27 shows the IFE estimation in the same time window for both outcomes, and the original estimation with the larger time window. The estimate retains the negative sign but is smaller and less precise under UNGA-DM: -0.027

with $p = 0.573$. However, the models are not the same, since the number of latent factors chosen by cross-validation is different: 2 under BSV and 1 under UNGA-DM. The 2×2 comparison below holds the common window and country-year panel fixed while crossing the outcome source with one versus two latent factors, allowing the factor-count component to be assessed separately.

Table 27: Cross-country interactive fixed-effects panel under the two outcome sources, in a common window with identical rows.

Specification	ATT	SE	95 percent CI	p	Factors (CV)	Country-years
BSV full window 1990-2022 (paper main, stored target)	-0.101	0.039	[-0.177, -0.024]	0.010	2	5,037
BSV common window (≤ 2020 , identical rows)	-0.095	0.040	[-0.173, -0.018]	0.016	2	4,727
UNGA-DM common window (≤ 2020 , identical rows)	-0.027	0.048	[-0.120, 0.066]	0.573	1	4,727

Note:

All rows use the goods-only status-current restricted risk set with 35 treated and 126 control countries. The common-window rows keep exactly the same country-years in both outcome sources. Confidence intervals come from 10,000 bootstrap replications.

Table 28 holds the common window and country-year panel fixed and crosses the two outcome sources with one and two latent factors. This 2×2 design isolates the factor-count component of the comparison. Holding the outcome fixed, moving from one to two factors makes the ATT more negative (larger in absolute value): from -0.036 to -0.095 under BSV, and from -0.027 to -0.065 under UNGA-DM. Cross-validation selects 2 factors under BSV and 1 under UNGA-DM. The one-factor UNGA-DM fit selected by cross-validation has the same negative sign and substantially overlapping uncertainty with the fixed-two-factor fit, although its point estimate is less negative; factor selection therefore changes magnitude without reversing the qualitative pattern. Holding the factor count at two still leaves a smaller UNGA-DM estimate (-0.065) than the BSV estimate (-0.095), so the outcome source remains relevant after the factor-count component is isolated.

Table 28: Outcome source by number of latent factors, holding the panel fixed.

Outcome	Factors (fixed)	Selected by CV	ATT	SE	95 percent CI	p
BSV	1	No	-0.036	0.037	[-0.109, 0.037]	0.336
UNGA-DM	1	Yes	-0.027	0.048	[-0.120, 0.066]	0.573
BSV	2	Yes	-0.095	0.040	[-0.173, -0.018]	0.016
UNGA-DM	2	No	-0.065	0.055	[-0.172, 0.043]	0.238

Note:

Same common window and identical rows as the previous table. Paired bootstrap on the difference between the two ATTs, 1,000 replications and no failures: 0.069 (percentile $p = 0.134$) under procedure-selected factor counts, and 0.030 (percentile $p = 0.356$) with common factors.

To sum up, the Brazilian SDiD result retains its negative direction and inferential support across the two outcome measurements, with similar relative magnitude but a different absolute scale. The 2×2 IFE comparison shows that two factors produce a more negative ATT under either outcome, while the one-factor choice selected by cross-validation for UNGA-DM remains qualitatively close to the two-factor fit, with the same sign and overlapping uncertainty. Even with two factors held fixed, the UNGA-DM estimate remains smaller than the BSV estimate, so the outcome metric contributes beyond factor selection. The paired test does not detect a statistically significant difference between the ATTs, but this non-rejection does not establish equivalence and may reflect uncertainty.